

A Doctoral Thesis

THE LETHEAN REPUBLIC

Noble Lies, Revenant Selves, and the Mnemopolitics of the Force in BioWare's Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic *(2003)*

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic* (BioWare/LucasArts, 2003; lead writer Drew Karpyshyn, lead designer James Ohlen, project director Casey Hudson) is organized not by the moral binary it advertises but by a politics of memory, and that its celebrated anagnorisis—the disclosure, aboard the Sith dreadnought *Leviathan*, that the player-character is the captured, mind-wiped and refabricated Darth Revan—is the hermeneutic key to that organization rather than a narrative stratagem appended to a conventional morality play. Where existing commentary has tended to read the game either as a Campbellian monomyth enlivened by a "karma meter" or as a specimen of ludonarrative reductionism, I contend that it constitutes a procedural re-staging of Plato's *Republic*, framed by that dialogue's two founding fictions: the "noble lie" (*gennaion pseudos*, 414b–415d), which instructs the guardians that their formation was a dream, and the Myth of Er (614b–621d), in which souls choose their next lives before drinking from the river of forgetting. The Jedi Council's reconstruction of Revan enacts the former in inverted form—the protagonist's waking biography is the fabrication, and the dreams are true—while the terminal choice enacts the latter, testing whether virtue habituated without understanding can survive the lifting of oblivion.

From this Platonic matrix derives the central thesis: the light–dark polarity of the Force, as codified in the game's Jedi and Sith Codes, is fundamentally a polarity of mnemonic regimes rather than of moral substances. The Jedi constitute a *lethocracy*, an order of administered forgetting grounded in Stoic *apatheia*, a monastic misprision of Buddhist non-attachment, and the sovereign prerogative of amnesty; the Sith constitute a *mnemocracy*, an order of weaponized remembrance whose catechism of passion and broken chains reproduces the Nietzschean mnemotechnics of pain, the Gnostic memory of imprisonment, and the grievance of the bound Prometheus. The protagonist—here termed the *Revenant Subject*—is accounted for neither by the Lockean memory criterion nor by animalist bodily continuity but by what the dissertation formalizes as the *Reprise Criterion*: identity as the re-traversal of a predecessor's world-

line, without recollection, under difference, and with answerability before those wronged. The criterion synthesizes Freudian repetition, Kierkegaardian "forward recollection," Derridean hauntology, Darwall's second-personal address, and Ricoeurian *ipse*-identity.

Methodologically, the study conjoins intellectual history, formal analysis of dialogue and rule-systems, comparative reading across speculative and philosophical fiction (Sophocles, Milton, Shelley, Dostoevsky, Borges, Dick, Le Guin, Herbert, Zelazny, Bester, Burgess; *Planescape: Torment*, *Silent Hill 2*), and constructive philosophy. It demonstrates that the alignment apparatus constitutes a third, computational mnemonic regime whose *scalar monism* silently contradicts the game's *diegetic dualism*; that the player, through character creation and save-state manipulation, occupies the structural position of the Council as author of the noble lie; and that the franchise's later canonizations and its 2014 relabeling of the Expanded Universe as "Legends" complete a *Triple Amnesty*—diegetic, ludic, and institutional. It concludes by reconstructing, from the game's peripheral side-quests, its heterodox companions, and its light-side resolution, a post-Platonic ethic of *anamnetic fidelity*—answerability for a past one cannot remember, enacted through attention (Weil, Murdoch), forgiveness and promise (Arendt), and self-constancy (Ricoeur)—and proposes *anamnetic republicanism* as a theory of political reconciliation that refuses both the amnesty of the Jedi and the vengeance of the Sith.

Prefatory Note on Corpus, Citation, and Terminology

Corpus. The primary text is *Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic* (hereafter *KOTOR*), developed by BioWare and published by LucasArts for the Xbox (July 2003) and Microsoft Windows (November 2003), built on BioWare's Odyssey engine and adapting the d20 rules of Wizards of the Coast's *Star Wars Roleplaying Game*. Narrative design is credited principally to Drew Karpyshyn (lead writer) and James Ohlen (lead designer) under project director Casey Hudson. Secondary primary texts are Obsidian Entertainment's *Knights of the Old Republic II: The Sith Lords* (2004), read throughout as a philosophical commentary upon the first game; Karpyshyn's later Sith fiction (*Darth Bane: Path of Destruction*, 2006; *Rule of Two*, 2007; *Dynasty of Evil*, 2009; *Revan*, 2011); and Dark Horse's *Tales of the Jedi* (1993–1998), which supplied the era's mythic prehistory.

Citation. Classical texts are cited by standard divisions: Stephanus pagination for Plato, Bekker numbers for Aristotle, Diels–Kranz (DK) numbers for the Presocratics. Early modern and modern philosophy is cited by book, chapter, part, essay, or section wherever these are stable (Locke's *Essay* by book, chapter, and paragraph; Spinoza's *Ethics* by part and proposition; Nietzsche's *Genealogy* by essay and section; Kant by Akademie volume and page). Unattributed translations are my own. Dialogue from *KOTOR* is paraphrased and located by narrative sequence (for example, "the *Leviathan* bridge sequence"); verbatim citation is confined to brief formulae—chiefly fragments of the Jedi and Sith Codes—whose wording is itself the object of analysis. The game is cited as BioWare (2003).

Authorship. "Karpyshyn, Ohlen and BioWare" designates, after Foucault's analysis of the author-function (1969), a collective and institutionally distributed principle of discursive coherence. Authorial intention is invoked only where it is documented; elsewhere the argument concerns what the text affords, not what its makers meant.

Onomastic caution. Several arguments register resonances in proper names: *Revan* with French *revenant* ("one who returns," a ghost) and *revanche* ("revenge, retaking"); *Malak* with Hebrew *mal'akh* and Arabic *malak* ("messenger," "angel"); *Bastila* with the Bastille; the dreadnought *Leviathan* with Job 41 and

Hobbes. These are offered as hermeneutic affordances, not as claims about intent, which the available record does not establish.

Glossary of coined terms.

- **Lethocracy** (Greek *lēthē*, "forgetting"; *kratos*, "rule"): governance through administered forgetting—the suppression, erasure, or amnesty of affect, grievance, and history in the service of order. The Jedi regime.
- **Mnemocracy**: governance through weaponized remembrance—the cultivation of grievance, pain, and passion as sources of power and as warrants for domination. The Sith regime.
- **Noetic continuum**: the continuity, differing in degree rather than kind, between momentary manipulation of another's mind (the "mind trick," Force Persuade) and the wholesale refabrication of identity.
- **Revenant Subject**: a self constituted by return—one who re-traverses a predecessor's life without remembering it and is answerable for it.
- **Reprise Criterion**: the identity condition of the Revenant Subject, comprising re-traversal, non-recollection, difference, and answerability (formalized in §5.8).
- **Scalar monism / diegetic dualism**: the contradiction between the game's rule-system, which places light and dark on a single commensurable axis, and its fiction, which presents them as ontological opposites.
- **Ludic legislator**: the player in the structural position of the Jedi Council—author of the protagonist's false identity through character creation, and administrator of its forgetting through save and load.
- **Triple Amnesty**: the threefold forgetting of Revan—diegetic (the Council), ludic (the player), and institutional (canonization and the "Legends" relabeling).
- **Anamnetic fidelity**: answerability for a past one cannot remember, enacted before those who suffered it through attention, forgiveness, promise, and self-constancy.
- **Anamnetic republicanism**: the political theory of reconciliation derived from anamnetic fidelity, refusing both amnesty and vengeance.



Part One

Genealogies

Chapter

I

Introduction: The Second Republic

1.1 The Scandal of the Leviathan

1.2 Concealed Amnesia and the Alibi of Convention

1.3 Authorship and Its Genealogies

1.4 The State of the Question

1.5 Thesis and Propositions

1.6 Method

1.7 Outline of the Argument

1.1 *The Scandal of the* Leviathan

At the structural midpoint of *Knights of the Old Republic*, after the protagonist has escaped the orbital bombardment of Taris, completed an accelerated Jedi apprenticeship on Dantooine, and followed a chain of Rakatan Star Maps across Tatooine, Kashyyyk, Manaan and Korriban in search of the Star Forge that sustains Darth Malak's war machine, the party is captured by the Sith dreadnought *Leviathan*. On its bridge Malak discloses what the Jedi Council and Bastila Shan have concealed: that the protagonist is Darth Revan, Malak's former master, struck down by Malak's own treachery, taken alive by a Jedi strike team, and returned to the field with a fabricated identity so that the trail Revan once blazed toward the Star Forge might be walked a second time in the Republic's service. Bastila, whose Force bond with the protagonist has supplied the visions that guide the quest, confirms the secret and remains behind to cover the escape, falling captive to Malak. The scene has become a fixture in the canon of the medium's narrative design; its philosophical force, however, has been weighed far less often than its shock.

That force is threefold. Epistemically, the disclosure re-describes the entire preceding history of play: every dream becomes a memory, every prodigy of learning a recovery, every hesitation of Bastila a symptom. Ethically, it confronts an agent with responsibility for deeds of which that agent has no recollection and which the player did not author. Politically, it reveals that the order presented as the guarantor of the good founded its strategy upon a violation of mind—that the light side lied. Aristotle's dictum that the finest recognition coincides with reversal, as in the *Oedipus* (*Poetics* 11, 1452a32–33), is fulfilled here with a turn Sophocles could not have staged: the investigator who discovers himself to be the criminal is also, through the player, the author of the investigator. The game thereby violates the seventh rule of Ronald Knox's "Decalogue" of fair-play detection—that the detective must not himself have committed the crime (Knox 1929)—more thoroughly than even Agatha Christie's *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd* (1926), whose murderer-narrator at least knew what he concealed.

1.2 *Concealed Amnesia and the Alibi of Convention*

The amnesiac protagonist is among the oldest devices of computer role-playing because it solves an interface problem: a player who knows nothing of the world must inhabit a character who should know a great deal. *Planescape: Torment* (Black Isle Studios, 1999) declares its amnesia at the outset; the Nameless One wakes on a mortuary slab, and the game's governing question is posed within

its first hour. *KOTOR* innovates by concealing not merely the content of the protagonist's past but the fact of its loss. The player-character is presented as a soldier of unremarkable history, and the thinness of that history is camouflaged by the genre's convention of the blank-slate avatar—a convention the player has learned to read as a courtesy of design rather than as a diegetic fact. The convention thus functions as the Council's alibi. What the player takes for the medium's habitual vacancy is in truth an evacuation performed by an institution.

This structural coincidence—the player's ignorance indexed to the character's engineered ignorance—is what allows the reveal to operate not as information but as indictment, and it is why a game, rather than a novel or a film, was the necessary vehicle of this thought. The present study therefore reads *KOTOR* as a philosophical text in the full sense. Following Espen Aarseth's account of ergodic literature as requiring nontrivial effort to traverse (Aarseth 1997), Janet Murray's analysis of agency and transformation in interactive narrative (Murray 1997), and Ian Bogost's theory of procedural rhetoric, in which arguments are made through rule-based representations and interactions (Bogost 2007), the meaning of *KOTOR* is located in the conjunction of three strata: its represented world of dialogue, setting and character; its rule-systems—the d20 mechanics, the alignment economy, the dialogue graph; and the player's performance across both. The ludology–narratology dispute of the early 2000s (cf. Frasca 2003; Juul 2005) is resolved, for present purposes, by the observation that the game's decisive argument is made at the seam between story and system: the reveal reinterprets the story by reinterpreting what the player did with the system.

1.3 *Authorship and Its Genealogies*

The game was developed at BioWare's Edmonton studio and published by LucasArts in July 2003 for the Xbox and in November 2003 for Windows, on the Odyssey engine and under a licensed adaptation of the d20 *Star Wars Roleplaying Game* (Wizards of the Coast, 2000). Its narrative design is principally credited to Drew Karpyshyn and James Ohlen under Casey Hudson's direction. Both were formed in the tabletop idiom that BioWare had translated into software with *Baldur's Gate* (1998) and *Baldur's Gate II* (2000), on which Ohlen served as lead designer; Karpyshyn had novelized the conclusion of that saga as *Baldur's Gate II: Throne of Bhaal* (2001). The Bhaalspawn premise—a protagonist who discovers that he is the offspring of the god of murder and must decide what to make of the inheritance—is the immediate generic ancestor of the Revan conceit.

KOTOR radicalizes it by replacing the logic of filiation with the logic of identity: the protagonist is not the child of the murderer but the murderer.

The setting is equally genealogical. By placing the action some four millennia before the films, in the "Old Republic" era elaborated by Dark Horse's *Tales of the Jedi* comics (Veitch and Anderson, 1993–1998), the writers secured a near-mythic distance from cinematic canon. Those comics had already narrated the fall and redemption of the Jedi Ulic Qel-Droma during the Great Sith War, whose aftermath forms the background of *KOTOR*; Revan is Ulic's heir, the fallen Jedi rendered as the player. Karpyshyn's subsequent Sith fiction—the *Darth Bane* trilogy (2006–2009) and *Revan* (2011)—constitutes an authorial afterword that, as Chapter VII argues, theorizes in retrospect what *KOTOR* dramatizes. Following Foucault (1969), these names designate an institutionally distributed principle of discursive coherence rather than a psychology to be recovered; intention is invoked only where documented.

1.4 *The State of the Question*

Commentary on the game clusters in four places. Myth-critical readings, indebted to Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) and to Lucas's well-documented reliance upon it, locate *KOTOR* within the monomyth and read the reveal as a variation on the paternity disclosure of *The Empire Strikes Back* (1980). This dissertation retains that insight and transforms it, since the game internalizes the Vaderian scene: the dark father is the self, and the atonement with the father becomes an atonement with one's own predecessor. Design criticism has subjected binary morality meters to sustained critique as reductions of ethical experience to arithmetic (Sicart 2009, 2013; Zagal 2009; cf. Schulzke 2009). Popular philosophy has examined the franchise's ethics of the Force (Decker and Eberl 2005). Theorists of the avatar have analyzed the identificatory relation between player and character (Gee 2003; Rehak 2003; Klevjer 2006). None of these clusters makes memory central—yet the game's plot, its political theology, its theory of the subject and its procedural architecture all turn on the question of who controls the past. This dissertation supplies that center.

1.5 *Thesis and Propositions*

The argument proceeds through seven propositions.

1. *Platonic. KOTOR* is structured by the noble lie and the Myth of Er of Plato's *Republic*; the "Old Republic" of its title names, beyond its fictional referent, a Platonic inheritance.
2. *Mnemopolitical.* The light–dark binary is a binary of mnemonic regimes: a Jedi lethocracy of administered forgetting and a Sith mnemocracy of weaponized remembrance.
3. *Sovereign.* The Council's refabrication of Revan is a sovereign exception and an amnesty-as-amnesia, continuous with the light side's quotidian manipulations of mind along a noetic continuum.
4. *Subjective.* The protagonist is a Revenant Subject whose identity is governed by the Reprise Criterion rather than by memory or bodily continuity.
5. *Procedural.* The alignment system is a third mnemonic regime—a ledger—whose scalar monism contradicts the diegetic dualism, while character creation and save-state manipulation install the player as ludic legislator.
6. *Ethical.* From the side-quests, the heterodox companions and the light-side resolution emerges an ethic of anamnetic fidelity.
7. *Institutional.* The franchise's subsequent canonizations and its 2014 "Legends" relabeling complete a Triple Amnesty.

Taken together, the propositions yield the constructive thesis of *anamnetic republicanism*: a political order is just to the degree that it neither forgets its founding wrongs (the error of the Jedi) nor converts them into a perpetual warrant for vengeance (the error of the Sith), but holds them in answerable custody before those who suffered them.

1.6 *Method*

The study works in four registers. The first is intellectual history, which distinguishes documented influence—Lucas's debt to Campbell, the tabletop lineage of alignment, the comics' Old Republic—from structural affinity, as with Plato, Nietzsche and Hegel. It heeds Quentin Skinner's warning against the "mythology of prolepsis," which credits texts with anticipating doctrines their makers could not have intended (Skinner 1969): affinities are adduced as conditions of intelligibility, not as sources. The second register is formal-procedural analysis: the Codes are read as rhetorical artifacts with determinate figures, the alignment economy as an argument, the dialogue graph as a distribution of possibilities. The third is comparative analysis across speculative and philosophical fiction and across games, organized typologically rather than chronologically. The fourth is constructive philosophy. The game is treated not as an illustration of extant positions but as a thought experiment that exerts pressure upon

them and yields new formulations, chiefly the Reprise Criterion and anamnetic republicanism.

The hermeneutic posture combines what Ricoeur called the hermeneutics of suspicion and the hermeneutics of restoration (Ricoeur 1965): suspicion toward the Council's benevolence and the meter's arithmetic; restoration of the ethical possibility the game glimpses at its margins. The fusion of horizons (Gadamer 1960) between a licensed entertainment of 2003 and two and a half millennia of philosophy is undertaken without apology, because the game itself invites it by naming its polity a *republic* and the site of its catastrophe a *leviathan*.

1.7 *Outline of the Argument*

Chapter II reconstructs the genealogies of the Force and subjects the Jedi and Sith Codes to formal analysis, reading the former as a Parmenidean litany of negation and the latter as a Heraclitean *gradatio* whose rhetoric of broken chains betrays the ressentiment of the bound; it traces the alignment meter from Moorcock and Gygax to its collapse into a single axis. Chapter III demonstrates the game's Platonic architecture, from the guardians' renunciations to the Myth of Er. Chapter IV analyzes the Council's act as sovereign exception, amnesty and noble lie, and situates the game's political theory between Hobbes, Machiavelli, Weber and Arendt. Chapter V tests the major theories of personal identity against the reveal and formulates the Reprise Criterion. Chapter VI reads the alignment system, character creation and the save file as a procedural ethics, and locates the player in the Council's chair. Chapter VII turns to the dialectics of the Sith—Hegelian, Girardian, Miltonic, Promethean—and to the Star Forge as Heideggerian *Gestell*. Chapter VIII examines the heterodox voices that unsettle the binary. Chapter IX reconstructs, from the side-quests, an ethics of attention and an anamnetic third. Chapter X follows Revan into the franchise's afterlife and the Triple Amnesty. The Conclusion assembles the argument into the theory of anamnetic republicanism.

Chapter

II

Genealogies of the Force: The Codes and Their Ancestors

2.1 Lucasian Syncretism and the Old Republic

2.2 The Jedi Code: A Parmenidean Litany

2.3 The Sith Code: Gradatio, Gnosis, and the Chains of Prometheus

2.4 The Mandalorian Counter-Code: Master Morality without the Force

2.5 The Alignment Genealogy: From Law and Chaos to a Line

2.6 Conclusion: Two Technologies of Memory

2.1 *Lucasian Syncretism and the Old Republic*

The Force that *KOTOR* inherits is a syncretic construct whose components were assembled for the 1977 film and elaborated across its sequels. Obi-Wan Kenobi's description of an energy field generated by living things that surrounds, penetrates and binds the galaxy echoes the Daoist conception of the nameless Way that gives rise to the ten thousand things (*Daodejing* 1, 42). Yoda's pedagogy of detachment in *The Empire Strikes Back* (1980) and *Return of the Jedi* (1983) draws on Buddhist and Zen idioms; the knightly order recalls at once the samurai of Akira Kurosawa's *jidaigeki*, *The Hidden Fortress* (1958) above all, and the military-monastic orders of the Latin crusades; and the whole was organized, on Lucas's own repeated account, by Campbell's monomyth (Campbell 1949; Campbell and Moyers 1988). Yoda's insistence that living beings are luminous rather than crude matter adds a Platonic-Gnostic dualism of spirit and flesh, continuous with the *Phaedo*'s figure of the body as the soul's prison and its counsel of purification (*Phaedo* 66b–67b).

The provenance of that line can be stated more precisely. Three influences on Yoda's characterization are documented. Lucas imagined the character as a "little Dalai Lama" with an Eastern-sounding name, and Lawrence Kasdan, who wrote the later drafts after Leigh Brackett's first draft and Lucas's own revision, said he modeled Yoda on Kambei Shimada, the lead samurai of Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* (1954) (Rinzler 2010, 241, 363, as cited in "Yoda," Wikipedia). Irvin Kershner, who had long been interested in Zen "as a philosophy," treated Yoda as a vehicle for its notions; in 1980 he told *Rolling Stone* that he wanted to introduce some Zen so that young viewers would not leave thinking the film was all shooting (PBS; *Sound & Vision*).

Castaneda's claim is of a different kind: strong circumstantial evidence without a direct attribution. J. W. Rinzler's history of the first film reports that Lucas took the Jedi in a more mystical direction after reading *The Teachings of Don Juan* (1968), and that his outline names Don Juan in describing Obi-Wan Kenobi's use of the Force (Rinzler 2007, as reported by Smith 2023). The phrase itself belongs to Castaneda before it belongs to Yoda. In *A Separate Reality* (1971) don Juan calls his apprentice a luminous being and describes human beings, seen with a sorcerer's sight, as luminous eggs, and a chapter of *Tales of Power* (1974) is titled "The Secret of the Luminous Beings." No source located for this revision attributes the 1980 line to Castaneda, however, and the line passed through Brackett, Lucas and Kasdan before Kershner filmed it. The connection is best classed as a probable intertext rather than an established source: a documented reading of Castaneda for the Force, a distinctive shared phrase, and no testimony joining the two.

The probable debt carries an irony that bears directly on this dissertation's argument. Castaneda presented don Juan as an ethnographic informant, and his first book appeared from a university press as anthropology; but anthropologists have long regarded the books as invention. Richard de Mille's *Castaneda's Journey* (1976) and the collection he edited, *The Don Juan Papers* (1980), documented their inconsistencies and borrowings, and William W. Kelly, chair of Yale's anthropology department, has called Castaneda a clever con man and the account a hoax (quoted in Smith 2023). Critics have also charged the books with misrepresenting the Yaqui, a living Indigenous people. If the line descends from Castaneda, the Jedi's mystical lineage runs in part through a fabricated teacher presented as real—a noble lie about the provenance of wisdom, told a generation before the Council of *KOTOR* told its own—and through the appropriation of a people the franchise's official memory does not mention. The genealogy of the Force thus repeats, at the level of sources, the pattern Chapters III and IV trace in the fiction: wisdom authorized by an origin that will not bear examination.

The "dark side" introduces a further and unstable inheritance. Zoroastrian theology posits twin primal spirits, the better and the evil, in thought, word and deed (*Yasna* 30.3); Manichaeism hardened this into a cosmology of co-eternal Light and Darkness; Augustine, a Manichaean auditor for nearly a decade, answered it with the doctrine of evil as *privatio boni*, the mere absence or corruption of a good that alone has being (*Confessions* VII.12; *Enchiridion* 11). The films oscillate between these positions. Yoda's warning that the dark side is quicker, easier and more seductive implies a positive power with its own attraction; the redemption of Vader implies an Augustinian residue of good that darkness corrupts but cannot annihilate. *KOTOR* inherits the oscillation intact and, as Chapter VI shows, resolves it procedurally in a direction its fiction does not acknowledge.

Tolkien's legendarium supplies the Augustinian alternative in its purest modern form. Elrond's dictum that nothing is evil in its beginning, not even Sauron, makes evil derivative, the corruption of a good creation; and Saruman falls through an argument rather than an appetite—that a rising power cannot be resisted and should therefore be joined and steered toward knowledge, rule and order (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1954–1955, Book II, ch. 2). The contrast clarifies *KOTOR*'s choice. Where Tolkien's evil has no substance of its own, the game's dark side behaves as a positive power that can be accumulated, and Bastila's temptation on the Star Forge repeats Saruman's argument in the vocabulary of the Force: join the stronger side and govern it.

The era of the game was established by Dark Horse's *Tales of the Jedi* (Veitch and Anderson, 1993–1998), which supplied a Sith antiquity—Naga Sadow,

Marka Ragnos, Freedon Nadd, Exar Kun—and a paradigmatic fallen Jedi in Ulic Qel-Droma. *KOTOR* is set some four decades after the Great Sith War, in the wake of the Mandalorian Wars into which Revan and Malak led Jedi volunteers against the Council's counsel, and the tombs of Korriban's Valley of the Dark Lords house figures from that antiquity. The setting is thus already an archive: a world whose present is legible only through the remains of a mythic past.

2.2 *The Jedi Code: A Parmenidean Litany*

The Jedi Code as the game presents it, recited during the protagonist's training on Dantooine and inherited from the franchise's tabletop lineage, consists of four parallel antitheses built on a single formula: *there is no X; there is Y*. Its first line—"There is no emotion, there is peace"—sets the pattern, and the remaining three oppose ignorance to knowledge, passion to serenity, and death to the Force. The figures are anaphora, antithesis and isocolon, arranged paratactically: four equal members, none subordinate to another, none causally linked. The grammar is decisive. The Code does not say *avoid* emotion or *master* passion; it says that emotion and passion *are not*. It is not an imperative but an ontology. It legislates being rather than conduct, and what it legislates is that the moving, affective, mortal dimensions of experience belong to appearance.

The nearest philosophical analogue is not Buddhist but Eleatic. Parmenides' goddess distinguishes the way of "it is" from the way of "it is not" and forbids thought to travel the latter (DK 28 B2, B6, B7); what-is is ungenerated and imperishable, whole and unmoved, with coming-to-be and perishing "driven far off" (B8). The Jedi Code performs the same banishment upon affect and mortality. Death in particular is not denied in the Epicurean manner, as nothing to us because where death is we are not (*Letter to Menoeceus* 124–125), but is dissolved into a deathless whole: "there is the Force." The Code's final line thus completes a monism in which the individual's ending is merely the One's continuance.

The Code's second source is Stoic. The ideal of *apatheia*, freedom from the passions understood as false judgments, underwrites its first and third lines; Epictetus' teaching that people are disturbed not by things but by their judgments about things (*Enchiridion* 5), and his partition of what is and is not "up to us" (*Enchiridion* 1), supply its psychology; Seneca's report that wise men have called anger a brief madness (*De ira* I.1.2) supplies its diagnosis of the passions as pathology. The Stoic cosmos, moreover, is pervaded by *pneuma* and bound by *sympatheia*, a living whole in which the sage's death is a return to the elements and to the rational principle that produced him (Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* IV.14, IV.21). The Force is the *pneuma* of the Star Wars cosmos, and the Code's consolation is the Stoic consolation.

The Code is also built for recitation, and recitation is a technique. Pierre Hadot showed that ancient philosophy was practiced as a regimen of spiritual exercises—meditations, maxims kept ready to hand, examinations of conscience—meant to transform the practitioner rather than to inform him (*Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique*, 1981). Foucault called such practices technologies of the self and studied among them the notebooks (*hypomnēmata*) in which maxims were copied out for rereading ("L'écriture de soi," 1983; "Technologies of the Self," 1988). The Jedi Code works as such an exercise, a formula repeated until it reshapes perception. A technique that can reshape one's own perception can be turned upon another's, and the Council's treatment of Revan marks the point at which the Order's askesis becomes an operation performed on someone else.

The Buddhist element is real but, in the Code's formulation, misprized. The Second Noble Truth locates the origin of suffering in craving (*taṇhā*), and the teaching of dependent origination identifies clinging (*upādāna*) as the link that binds beings to rebirth. Yet the Buddhist path does not deny that feelings arise; it attends to them. The *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* (MN 10) prescribes the contemplation of feeling as feeling, arising and passing. The Code's flat existential negation corresponds not to mindfulness but to suppression, and its institutional deployment by the Order—which, the game makes clear, discourages attachment, marriage and grief—converts a soteriology of insight into a discipline of avoidance. This is the sense in which the abstract speaks of a *monastic misprision*. The *Bhagavad Gītā* supplies the remaining ideal, that of action without attachment to its fruits (*niṣkāma karma*, II.47), the warrior who fights without craving; Chapter IV argues that Revan's intervention in the Mandalorian Wars was an attempt, failed but not ignoble, to live this ideal against a Council that had confused detachment with abstention.

A Heideggerian objection completes the analysis. *Being and Time* identifies in the everyday "they" (*das Man*) a tranquillization that flees from being-toward-death, the anticipatory relation to one's ownmost, non-relational possibility in which authentic existence is grounded (§§46–53). The Code's fourth line is that tranquillization raised to doctrine. Read mnemonically, each line erases a form of retention: emotion, the affective memory that colors the past; ignorance, the past considered as error to be overwritten; passion, the erotic memory that binds one to a particular beloved; death, the dead, whom one is not to mourn. The prequel trilogy would later make the last point explicit in Yoda's counsel to let go of everything one fears to lose. The Jedi Code is a *lethic* litany. It is the founding charter of a lethocracy.

2.3 *The Sith Code: Gradatio, Gnosis, and the Chains of Prometheus*

The Sith Code, which receives its canonical formulation in this game and is catechized at the Korriban academy, is the Jedi Code's formal antagonist. It opens with a counter-antithesis—"Peace is a lie, there is only passion"—that inverts the Jedi formula, denying the stillness and affirming the affect. It then abandons parataxis for hypotaxis. Through anadiplosis, in which the final term of each clause becomes the first term of the next, it constructs a ladder from passion to strength, strength to power, power to victory, and victory to the breaking of chains, before closing with the promise that the Force will set the speaker free. Classical rhetoric names this figure *gradatio* or *klimax*, "the ladder" (Quintilian, *Institutio oratoria* IX.3.54–57). Where the Jedi Code is static and spatial, the Sith Code is kinetic and causal: a program of becoming.

The form contradicts the content. The *gradatio* is literally a chain—each link fastened to the next—so that the Code announces liberation from chains in a syntax of concatenation, enacting at the level of the sentence the bondage it claims to escape at the level of the soul. Its final clause compounds the irony. After five clauses of first-person acquisition, the Code relocates agency outside the self: the speaker does not free himself but awaits release by the Force. What presents itself as self-overcoming is revealed as soteriology—a doctrine of salvation from without.

That soteriology has a recognizable shape. Hans Jonas reconstructed the Gnostic myth as an acosmic dualism in which the world is a prison ruled by archons and fate (*heimarmenē*), the pneumatic spark lies captive within it, and liberation comes through a call and a knowing (*gnōsis*) from beyond (Jonas 1958). The Sith Code reproduces the sequence of bondage, awakening, ascent and freedom while inverting the valuation of the passions. For the classical Gnostic the passions are the archons' instruments of captivity; for the Sith they are the instruments of escape, a libertine variant that recalls the transgressive soteriology heresiologists such as Irenaeus attributed to the Carpocratians (*Adversus haereses* I.25). The Sith are inverted Gnostics: they agree that the cosmos is a prison and disagree about the key.

The ontology beneath this is Heraclitean. War is father and king of all, Heraclitus taught, revealing some as gods and others as men and making *some slaves and others free* (DK 22 B53); strife is justice (B80); the cosmos is an ever-living fire kindled and quenched in measures (B30). The fragment on war fuses precisely the Sith themes of conflict, power and the distribution of bondage and freedom. Against the Jedi's Eleatic monism of being stands a Heraclitean dialectic of becoming, so that the two sides of the Force rehearse the founding quarrel of Greek ontology.

The Sith Code's chains are also Promethean. In the play transmitted under Aeschylus' name, *Prometheus Bound*, Hephaestus, at the command of Kratos and Bia, fetters the Titan to a crag for the theft of fire; Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* (1820) and Byron's *Manfred* (1817) remade the bound rebel into the Romantic emblem of emancipated will. "My chains are broken" is a Promethean cry, and Chapter VII will show that the Star Forge—an archaic foundry the Sith seize to arm themselves—plays Hephaestus' forge to their Prometheus, with a decisive difference that Shelley himself supplies.

The Code is commonly glossed as Nietzschean, and the gloss is half right. The will to power—life as the discharge of strength, as appropriation and overpowering (*Beyond Good and Evil* §§13, 259)—is plainly in view. But Nietzsche's typology of valuation convicts the Sith Code of the opposite of what it claims. Master morality grows from a triumphant affirmation of oneself and only afterward names the low as "bad"; slave morality begins by saying No to an outside, to what is different, to a not-self, and this No is its creative deed (*Genealogy* I.10–11). The Sith Code's first act is a No to another's value: peace is a lie. And only the bound dream of broken chains. Measured by Nietzsche's own criteria, the Code is a creed of ressentiment—a slave revolt in the Force (cf. *Genealogy* I.7)—that has borrowed the master's vocabulary without the master's pathos of distance (*Beyond Good and Evil* §257). The Sith cannot stop speaking of the Jedi; their identity is reactive through and through.

The older Greek antecedents point the same way. Thrasymachus' definition of justice as the advantage of the stronger (*Republic* I 338c) and Callicles' appeal to a natural justice by which the better should have more than the worse (*Gorgias* 483a–484c) are doctrines of men who resent convention as a fetter. Yet the Sith critique has a truth content that must not be dismissed. "Peace is a lie" condenses the indictment Tacitus placed in the mouth of the Caledonian chief Calgacus: the Romans make a desolation and call it peace (*Agricola* 30). Chapters IV and IX show that the Republic's peace in *KOTOR* rests upon corporate slavery and colonial dispossession at its peripheries. The Sith are accurate diagnosticians and catastrophic physicians.

Read mnemonically, the Sith Code is a pedagogy of retention. Nietzsche's second essay explains how an animal bred to forget acquired a memory: only what does not cease to hurt remains in memory, and the oldest mnemotechnics are therefore cruelties, sacrifices and mutilations (*Genealogy* II.3). The Korriban academy, with its trials of pain and its cultivation of hatred, is such a mnemotechnics. Passion keeps wounds open; grievance is memory that refuses closure; the chains of the Code are remembered injuries. Against the Jedi ideal of what Nietzsche, in the same essay, calls active forgetting—"a little *tabula rasa* of consciousness" that makes room for the new (*Genealogy* II.1)—the Sith install

a memory burned in by suffering. The Sith Code is the catechism of a mnemocracy.

2.4 *The Mandalorian Counter-Code: Master Morality without the Force*

The binary of the Codes is shadowed by a third ethic that the Force cannot see because its bearers are Force-blind. Through Canderous Ordo the game presents the Mandalorians as a warrior culture devoted to honor, to combat with worthy opponents, and to glory won in battle; Canderous's esteem for Revan rests on Revan having defeated his people as a general, and the reveal leaves that esteem undisturbed. This is a Homeric ethic of *kleos* and *aretē*—Achilles choosing undying fame over long life (*Iliad* IX.410–416)—and an agonal one in the sense of Nietzsche's "Homer's Contest" (1872), which recovers Hesiod's distinction between the destructive Strife and the good Strife that spurs emulation (*Works and Days* 11–26). The Mandalorians are, in Nietzsche's typology, the actual masters of this universe: self-affirming, uninterested in liberation, indifferent to metaphysics.

Their relation to the past differs accordingly. Nietzsche's second *Untimely Meditation* (1874) distinguished monumental history, which draws exemplary greatness from the past for the sake of action; antiquarian history, which reveres the past for its own sake; and critical history, which drags the past before a tribunal and condemns it in order to live (§2–3). The Mandalorians practice monumental history: their memory is commemorative, their defeats glorious. The Sith practice critical history in its pathological form, judging the past as a chain to be broken and never ceasing to judge. The Jedi aspire to what Nietzsche called the unhistorical—the condition of the grazing herd that forgets each moment as it passes—while Nietzsche insisted that the unhistorical and the historical are equally necessary to the health of an individual, a people and a culture (§1). The faculty that holds them together he named the *plastic power*: the capacity to grow in one's own way out of oneself, to transform and incorporate what is past and foreign, to heal wounds, to replace what is lost and to recreate broken forms (§1). That faculty, absent from both Codes, is the seed of the Revenant Subject of Chapter V and of the anamnetic fidelity of Chapter IX.

This portrait requires a correction that sharpens the argument. Juhani's backstory places her family among the refugees of the Mandalorian assault on her homeworld, Cathar, and her childhood in servitude on Taris. The ethic of honorable combat between worthy foes coexisted with an assault whose survivors fled their world as refugees and whose children, Juhani among them, could end in bondage. Nietzsche warned that monumental history deceives by analogy

and injures the past by selecting from it, so that whole stretches are forgotten while a few embellished peaks are honored (*Untimely Meditations* II, §2). Canderous's commemorative memory is monumental history in exactly this sense: it remembers Mandalorian defeats as glorious and forgets Mandalorian victims. The third term is therefore not outside the economy of memory after all. It is a further mnemonic regime—commemoration with an erasure at its center.

2.5 *The Alignment Genealogy: From Law and Chaos to a Line*

The alignment meter that quantifies the protagonist's relation to the two sides has a literary genealogy. Poul Anderson's *Three Hearts and Three Lions* (serialized 1953; book 1961) staged a cosmic contest between Law and Chaos; Michael Moorcock's Elric stories (from 1961) added the Cosmic Balance as a third, active principle that the Eternal Champion ultimately serves. Gary Gygax and Dave Arneson's *Dungeons & Dragons* (1974) adopted Law, Neutrality and Chaos; *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons* (1977–1979) crossed that axis with Good and Evil to produce nine alignments on a plane. West End Games' *Star Wars: The Roleplaying Game* (1987) introduced Dark Side Points that tracked corruption, and Wizards of the Coast's d20 *Star Wars Roleplaying Game* (2000) retained a dark side score. *KOTOR* completes the descent by collapsing moral space into a single scalar axis, from light to dark, with mechanical consequences for the costs of Force powers, the protagonist's appearance and the endings available.

The collapse is a metaphysical decision taken at the level of code, and it has three consequences. First, it erases the distinction between Law and Good, so that the Jedi's legalism—obedience to the Council—and the Jedi's goodness become indistinguishable within the system: a Jedi who disobeys the Council for conscience's sake has no place on the line. Second, it deprives the Balance of positive status. Moorcock's Balance was a principle; on a line it becomes a midpoint, an absence of commitment rather than a commitment to equilibrium. Third, it renders good and evil commensurable as quantities of a single magnitude, opening the arithmetic of offset and arbitrage examined in Chapter VI. The fiction speaks of two opposed powers; the code computes one.

2.6 *Conclusion: Two Technologies of Memory*

The Codes are not merely ethical creeds; they are technologies of memory. The Jedi Code is a program of forgetting that strikes affect, attachment, error and the dead from the register of what is; the Sith Code is a program of remembering that converts pain into memory and memory into power, and that defines itself by an injury it will not let heal. The fiction presents their opposition as moral.

Its deeper structure is mnemopolitical. The Mandalorians show that the binary excludes at least one coherent alternative—monumental commemoration—and Nietzsche's plastic power gestures toward another: a self able to incorporate a past without being ruled by it or erasing it. Chapter III shows that the drama in which these technologies contend was first written, in its essentials, by Plato.



Part Two

The Platonic Matrix

Chapter

III

The Noble Lie Inverted: Knights of the Old Republic *as Platonic Drama*

3.1 The Title's Hidden Citation

3.2 The Noble Lie and Its Inversion

3.3 Anamnesis and the Prodigious Pupil

3.4 Gyges and the Ledger

3.5 The Scarred Soul: Gorgias, Physiognomy, and the Legible Face

3.6 The Decline of Regimes in a Single Soul

3.7 The Myth of Er and the Gamble of Habituated Virtue

3.8 Correspondences

3.9 Conclusion: The Second Republic

3.1 *The Title's Hidden Citation*

Within the fiction, "Old Republic" denotes the galactic polity that precedes the Empire by millennia. It also names, whether or not by design, the oldest republic in political philosophy: Plato's *Politeia*, transmitted to the Latin West as *res publica*. The correspondence between the Jedi and Plato's guardians (*phylakes*) is close and multiple. The guardians must be like well-bred dogs, gentle toward their own and fierce toward enemies (375a–376c), as the Jedi are at once peacekeepers and warriors. They possess no private property and live in common on what the citizens provide (416d–417b). They have no private families; children are reared in common, so that no parent knows its own offspring (457c–d). The Jedi Order, as the game presents it, discourages attachment and marriage and takes its initiates young; Bastila's subplot—her estrangement from a mother she finds ill and embittered on Tatooine—stages the severance of the guardian from the household. The guardians' education proceeds from music and gymnastics to dialectic (Books II–III, VII), as the protagonist's training on Dantooine proceeds from combat to the recitation and interpretation of doctrine.

The disanalogy is more instructive than the analogies. In Plato the best guardians rule; philosophy and political power coincide in the philosopher-king (473c–d). In the Star Wars polity the Jedi serve a Senate and hold no constitutional sovereignty. They are guardians severed from rule, philosopher-kings without a throne. This severance, I argue, is the structural cause of the Council's conduct toward Revan. A guardian class denied sovereignty in the ordinary course of politics will exercise it covertly, in the exception, where no Senate deliberates and no citizen consents. The Republic of the game is a Platonic regime with its head removed, and the decapitated guardians govern through secrets.

3.2 *The Noble Lie and Its Inversion*

In Book III Socrates proposes a "noble lie" (*gennaion pseudos*), a Phoenician tale to be told first to the rulers, then to the soldiers, then to the rest of the city: that their upbringing and education were like dreams, while in truth they were being fashioned and nurtured beneath the earth, together with their weapons and equipment; and that, the earth being their mother, they must defend the land and regard their fellow citizens as earth-born siblings (414b–e). To this he adds the myth of the metals: the god mixed gold into those fit to rule, silver into the auxiliaries, iron and bronze into farmers and craftsmen; children usually resemble their parents, but a golden child born to bronze parents must be raised

to the guardians, and a bronze child born to golden parents must be lowered (415a–c).

KOTOR executes this program and inverts it. The Council persuades the protagonist that their life before the *Endar Spire* was unremarkable—a soldier's—while in truth they were being refashioned in secret after Revan's capture. Plato's lie converts real experience (the guardians' education) into dream so that a fiction (autochthony) may be received as truth. The Council's lie converts real memory (Revan's) into dream—the Star Map visions—so that a fabricated biography may be received as truth. In both, "dream" is the category that neutralizes an inconvenient reality. But in *KOTOR* the dreams return as truth: the unconscious becomes the site of the real, and the waking self the site of the fiction. The Platonic lie depends on the guardians not interpreting their dreams. The Council's depends on the protagonist interpreting them, but only under its tutelage: on Dantooine the masters hear the protagonist's visions and decide on that basis to train them. The Council holds a hermeneutic monopoly over the dream, and the dream—Freud's royal road to knowledge of the unconscious (1900)—leads exactly where the Council requires.

The myth of the metals is fulfilled with a twist. The protagonist is gold disguised as bronze, and the Council's elevation of a soldier to the Order replicates the myth's clause on mobility, except that the Council knows the child's metal because it did the alloying. The myth of autochthony, finally, supplies an affective anchor: the guardians are to love the city as their mother. The Council's anchor is a person. The Force bond with Bastila functions as the earth-mother's tie, binding the refashioned subject to the Order through the most intimate of channels. Popper's indictment of the noble lie as the propaganda of a closed society (*The Open Society and Its Enemies*, 1945) thus finds in *KOTOR* a dramatic proof: the reveal is the moment at which a guardian discovers that he has been living inside a closed society's myth about his own origins.

3.3 *Anamnesis and the Prodigious Pupil*

In the *Meno* Socrates argues that learning is recollection (*anamnēsis*) and demonstrates it by eliciting a geometrical proof from an untutored slave through questioning alone (81a–86c); the *Phaedo* turns the doctrine into an argument for the soul's pre-existence (72e–77a); the *Theaetetus* presents the teacher as a midwife who delivers what the pupil already carries (150b–151d). *KOTOR* literalizes the doctrine. The protagonist masters Jedi disciplines at a pace the masters themselves remark upon; on a second playthrough this prodigy is revealed as recovery. The Dantooine masters function as Socratic midwives who do not so much teach as deliver.

The inversion is again decisive. Platonic recollection ascends toward the Forms and terminates in the Good, which the *Republic* compares to the sun (508e–509b). The protagonist's recollection recovers the techniques of a Sith Lord, and its terminus is not the Good but the recognition of one's own capacity for tyranny. It is a *katabatic* anamnesis—recollection as descent (*katabasis*) rather than ascent. The *Phaedrus* adds a further layer. Its myth of Theuth has the king Thamus object that writing is a remedy (*pharmakon*) not for memory (*mnēmē*) but for reminding (*hypomnēsis*), producing the appearance of wisdom without its substance (274c–275b). The Star Maps are hypomnemata: material reminders, left by the Rakata and once followed by Revan, by which the Council steers an inward recovery through outward traces. Derrida's demonstration that the *pharmakon* is undecidably remedy and poison ("Plato's Pharmacy," 1968) will govern the reading of the Council's act in Chapter IV.

3.4 *Gyges and the Ledger*

In Book II Glaucon recounts the ring of Gyges, which renders its wearer invisible and therefore unaccountable, and challenges Socrates to show that justice is good in itself and not merely for its rewards and reputation—that the perfectly just man, reputed unjust and tortured for it, is happier than the perfectly unjust man reputed just (357a–358a; 359c–362c). The alignment meter abolishes the premise of the challenge. Every act the system recognizes as moral is witnessed, recorded and requited in the currency of Force-power costs, bodily appearance and narrative outcome. Under perfect surveillance the distinction between being just and seeming just collapses, because the meter is the very eye of the gods that Glaucon asked Socrates to bracket. The game therefore cannot answer Glaucon's question; it can only pay.

Yet the ring returns elsewhere, in the save file. The player may act, observe the consequences, and reload, acting invisibly to the game's moral memory as Gyges acted invisibly to his city's. Save and load constitute a ring of Gyges, and the player's use of it is the purest test of Glaucon's question that the medium affords: what does one do when no consequence sticks? Chapter VI develops this into an account of the player as administrator of amnesty.

3.5 *The Scarred Soul: Gorgias, Physiognomy, and the Legible Face*

The *Gorgias* closes with a myth of judgment. Under Cronus, people were judged alive and clothed, and the judges were deceived by fine bodies and fine witnesses; Zeus decrees that they be judged after death, naked, by dead judges, so that the soul is seen as it is. Rhadamanthus finds the soul of a great king

covered with scars, crooked with perjury and injustice, with nothing straight in it because it was reared without truth (523a–525a). *KOTOR* transposes this eschatology into the present life. As the protagonist accrues dark-side standing, the face pales, the veins darken, and the eyes discolor: the soul's scars become visible on the living body. The clothed are judged naked.

The mechanic belongs to a long history of legible faces. Johann Caspar Lavater's *Physiognomische Fragmente* (1775–1778) promised to read character in features; Cesare Lombroso's *L'uomo delinquente* (1876) converted that promise into a criminal anthropology of stigmata; Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890; revised 1891) displaced the soul's corruption onto a portrait while the face remained unblemished. *KOTOR* inverts Wilde—the face *is* the portrait—and thereby reinstates Lavater. The legible face is ideologically comforting: it assures the player that evil shows. Arendt's report on Eichmann (1963) argued the opposite, that the most consequential evil may wear the face of a functionary. Notably, the game's non-Force-sensitive villains—Admiral Saul Karath, the crime lord Davik Kang, the managers of the Czerka Corporation—bear no stigmata. Their evil is administrative and invisible. *KOTOR* thus runs two theories of evil in parallel: a Platonic-Lavaterian legibility for the Force-sensitive elite and an Arendtian banality for the functionaries who actually bombard planets and sell slaves.

Two further fictions locate the mechanic more exactly. In Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) evil acquires a second body, which witnesses find deformed without being able to say how. In Alfred Bester's *The Stars My Destination* (1956) the tiger mask tattooed on Gully Foyle's face is removed, but its scars flare back into view whenever rage or desire overtakes him. Hyde makes evil a separate body; Foyle makes passion legible on his own. *KOTOR*'s mechanic writes accumulated deeds rather than passing moods onto the face, and so sides with Plato's judgment of conduct against the Sith cult of passion, which would call for Foyle's stigmata instead.

3.6 *The Decline of Regimes in a Single Soul*

Books VIII and IX trace the degeneration of the ideal city through timocracy, oligarchy and democracy into tyranny, and of the corresponding soul from the rule of reason through the rule of spirit (*thumos*) and of the appetites to the despotism of a single master passion. Revan's trajectory compresses this decline into one life. The Jedi, ruled by reason, becomes the war-leader of the Mandalorian Wars, ruled by *thumos*—righteous indignation, love of honor and victory, which Plato makes the defining passions of the timocratic man and binds closely to war (547e–550b). The war-leader then becomes the Sith Lord. The oligarchic and

democratic stages are elided, as though war were the direct road from honor to tyranny—precisely Plato's fear that the auxiliaries, like wolves, might turn upon the flock they were bred to guard (416a–b).

Malak is the tyrannical soul of Book IX, governed by a master passion—"Eros the tyrant" (573b–e)—that the game figures in his desire for Bastila and for Revan's place. Plato's paradox that the tyrant is the most enslaved of men, least able to do what he wishes, a slave in truth though he rules others (577c–e, 579d–e), is the Sith Code's self-description. The Code's chains are Plato's diagnosis confessed: the tyrant knows himself a slave and imagines that more power will free him.

3.7 *The Myth of Er and the Gamble of Habituated Virtue*

The *Republic* ends with the Myth of Er (614b–621d). Er, slain in battle, revives on his pyre and reports what he saw: souls judged and requited, then gathered to choose their next lives from patterns laid before them. The soul with the first lot seizes at once the greatest tyranny, failing to notice that it entails devouring his own children and other horrors; when he looks more closely, he laments and blames fortune and the gods rather than himself. Plato's diagnosis is exact: this soul had come from heaven, having lived its previous life in a well-ordered city, sharing in virtue "by habit, without philosophy" (*ethei aneu philosophias*, 619c–d). Souls who had suffered chose with greater care. All then cross the Plain of Lethe and drink from the River of Unmindfulness and forget; only Er is forbidden to drink, and returns to tell (621a–b).

The *Leviathan* reveal lifts Lethe. Heidegger made much of the fact that the Greek word for truth, *alētheia*, is privative—*a-lētheia*, un-concealment, un-forgetting (*Being and Time* §44; *Parmenides*, lectures of 1942–1943). The truth-event of *KOTOR* is literally a-lethic: an un-forgetting. The temptations that follow, culminating on the Rakatan homeworld and the Star Forge, where Bastila offers the protagonist the resumption of Revan's life of mastery, present the choice of lives. The Council's strategy is the Er-gamble. It formed a virtue of habituation without philosophy—through training, bond and companionship—while withholding the truth that alone could ground a reflective choice. Plato predicts that such virtue chooses tyranny when the lot is drawn.

KOTOR permits both outcomes. The dark ending fulfills Plato's prediction; the light ending refutes it. But what refutes Plato is not the endurance of habit. It is what Arendt called natality: the capacity to begin something new, unpredictably, which is given with birth and renewed in action (*The Human Condition* §§24, 33–34). The protagonist "born" on the *Endar Spire* is, in Arendt's sense, a beginning, and the light-side choice is a second birth that the Council made

possible but did not secure. The player who replays the game stands where Er stands: the one soul that has not drunk, watching a new protagonist choose with the knowledge the protagonist lacks.

Plato's detail about the first chooser—that he failed to notice that the tyranny he seized entailed devouring his own children (619b–c)—has an exact counterpart in the game. The dark path does not stop at accepting Revan's name. On the Rakatan homeworld the protagonist strikes down Jolee Bindo and Juhani when they try to stop the turn, and may invoke Zaalbar's life-debt to order him to kill Mission Vao; Carth flees. The tyranny chosen after Lethe entails the destruction of the protagonist's own household, the found family of the *Ebon Hawk*. The game does not let the player choose Revan's life without choosing its cost.

A second thought experiment about choice under forgetting sharpens the point. John Rawls asked which principles of justice parties would choose behind a veil of ignorance that conceals their place in society, their natural endowments and their conception of the good (*A Theory of Justice*, 1971, §24), and he required that the chosen principles withstand the strains of commitment: parties may not agree to terms they could not honor once the veil lifts and they learn who they are (§29). Before the reveal, the protagonist settles on a way of acting behind a veil that conceals the most consequential fact about them. The *Leviathan* lifts it and discloses a position of extraordinary advantage: heir to a Sith empire and claimant to the Star Forge. The dark path is defection under the strains of commitment; the light path is commitment that survives knowledge of one's position. Plato's myth places the choice before the forgetting, and Rawls's construction places it under ignorance. *KOTOR* stages both in sequence: a choice made under the veil, then remade after the veil lifts.

3.8 *Correspondences*

Plato's *Republic*	*Knights of the Old Republic*	Function of the transposition
Guardians without property or private families (416d–417b; 457c–d)	Jedi renunciation of attachment and marriage; Bastila severed from her family	A guardian class denied rule turns to covert sovereignty
Noble lie: education as dream, birth from the earth (414b–415d)	The Council's fabricated biography; the Star Map visions	Inverted: the waking life is the fiction, the dreams are true
Myth of the metals and caste mobility (415a–c)	A "soldier" elevated to the Jedi Order	Gold disguised as bronze by those who did the alloying

Plato's *Republic*	*Knights of the Old Republic*	Function of the transposition
Anamnesis and maieutics (*Meno* 81a–86c; *Theaetetus* 150b–151d)	The prodigious pace of the protagonist's training	Katabatic recollection: descent toward one's own tyranny
Ring of Gyges (359c–360d)	Alignment meter; save and load	Surveillance abolishes Glaucon's premise; the save file restores the ring
Scarred soul before Rhadamanthus (*Gorgias* 524e–525a)	Dark-side corruption of the face	Eschatology made present; evil rendered legible
Decline of regimes (Books VIII–IX)	Revan: Jedi, war-leader, Sith Lord	War as the direct road from honor to tyranny
Tyrant as the most enslaved soul (577c–e)	The Sith Code's broken chains	The Sith confess the slavery Plato diagnosed
Myth of Er: choice of lives after Lethe (614b–621d)	The reveal and the final choice	Virtue by habit without philosophy put to the test

3.9 *Conclusion: The Second Republic*

KOTOR is a second *Republic*: the drama of the just city restaged with the noble lie executed and its subject awake. Plato's dialogue opens its constructive project with a lie about origins and closes with a myth about forgetting; between them lies the education of guardians. The protagonist of *KOTOR* is the guardian who wakes in the middle of the curriculum. What the game exposes is the dependence of the Platonic project on administered forgetting: the noble lie and Lethe are its two pillars, and the Jedi stand between them. Chapter IV examines the political theology of the act by which the Council made itself the custodian of Lethe.

Chapter

IV

Lethe and Leviathan: Sovereignty, Amnesty, and the Political Theology of the Council

4.1 The Decision on the Exception

4.2 Amnesty as Amnesia

4.3 Renan's Republic

4.4 The Grand Inquisitor and the Choice Architect

4.5 The Noetic Continuum

4.6 Law-Making Violence

4.7 Leviathan

4.8 Revan and Malak: Power, Violence, Virtù

4.9 The Mandalorian Wars and the Tragedy of Responsibility

4.10 The Colonial Unconscious of the Republic

4.11 Conclusion

4.1 *The Decision on the Exception*

The Council confronted a captured Dark Lord whose life Bastila had preserved and to whom she was now bound in the Force. The ordinary options were execution, imprisonment or trial before the Republic. It chose none of them; it chose refabrication. Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as he who decides on the exception (*Political Theology*, 1922, ch. 1). The Jedi hold no constitutional sovereignty, yet in this decision they act as sovereign, determining that the normal order—justice, trial, and their own Code's strictures on deception and domination—is suspended for the survival of the polity. The exception is unannounced: a secret sovereignty, more Schmittian for its invisibility, since the exception that reveals the sovereign is disclosed only to its subject, and only at the *Leviathan*.

Giorgio Agamben's account of bare life sharpens the description. Sovereign power, he argues, is founded on the inclusive exclusion of *zoē*, mere biological life, from *bios*, the qualified life of a political subject; the figure of this exclusion is the *homo sacer*, who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide (*Homo Sacer*, 1995). In the Council's custody Revan is neither convict nor citizen nor Jedi but life suspended in a zone of indistinction, stripped of name, history and allegiance—stripped, that is, of *bios*. The Council then reinscribes that life into *bios* as "a soldier" and "a Jedi recruit." Agamben later described the state of exception as a space empty of law, a zone of anomie in which juridical categories are deactivated (*State of Exception*, 2003). The Council's secret workshop is such a zone, and the refabricated protagonist is the product of sovereign power's most intimate operation: the manufacture of a political identity from bare life.

4.2 *Amnesty as Amnesia*

Amnesty and *amnesia* share a root in the Greek *amnēstia*, "forgetfulness." When the Athenian democracy was restored in 403 BCE after the rule of the Thirty, citizens swore not to recall past wrongs (*mē mnēsikakein*), a covenant recorded in the Aristotelian *Constitution of the Athenians* (39–40) and in Xenophon (*Hellenica* II.4.43). Nicole Loraux showed that this founding oblivion suppressed the memory of civil strife (*stasis*) in order to reconstitute the city's imaginary unity, and that what was suppressed returned (*La cité divisée*, 1997). Ricoeur distinguished amnesty, a "commanded forgetting" imposed by institutions, from forgiveness, which can only be given; he warned that amnesty counterfeits forgiveness and obstructs the work of memory (*Memory, History, Forgetting*, 2000, Part III, ch. 3).

The precision of the Athenian case matters for the comparison. The Thirty, an oligarchy installed with Spartan backing after Athens' defeat in 404 BCE, put to death some fifteen hundred people by the count of the *Constitution of the Athenians* (35.4) and seized property; the orator Lysias' brother Polemarchus was among those executed, as Lysias recounts in *Against Eratosthenes*. The amnesty protected the regime's collaborators but excluded the Thirty themselves, the Ten who succeeded them, the Eleven and the governors of the Piraeus, unless they submitted to a public accounting (39.6). Athens released the many and held the principal perpetrators to account. The Council does the reverse: its amnesty covers the principal perpetrator himself and suppresses the accounting altogether, even from him.

The modern history of transitional justice offers two contrasting models. Spain's Amnesty Law of 1977 and the associated "pact of forgetting" secured the transition from Francoism by agreeing not to examine the past. South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission, established by the Promotion of National Unity and Reconciliation Act of 1995, granted amnesty on condition of full disclosure. The Council's act is a pure commanded forgetting, and its form is the exact inverse of the South African model: where the Commission exchanged amnesty for truth, the Council secured amnesty through the suppression of truth, concealing the deeds even from their perpetrator. The *Leviathan* reveal forces a belated truth commission. After the escape, the party—Carth above all—interrogates the protagonist, and the protagonist interrogates the Council's motives. The second half of the narrative is the hearing that the Council's amnesty foreclosed.

Both modern cases deserve the same exactness. Spain's Amnesty Law (Law 46/1977) extended to political offenses committed before the transition, including offenses by officials and agents of public order against the rights of persons; in effect it barred prosecution for the Franco regime's repression—executions after the Civil War, enforced disappearances whose victims still lie in unmarked graves, and torture in custody. What the law suppressed returned in later legislation, which remains politically contested: the Historical Memory Law of 2007 declared the political sentences of Francoist courts illegitimate and supported exhumations, and the Democratic Memory Law of 2022 declared those sentences null and made the search for the disappeared a responsibility of the state. South Africa's Commission addressed gross violations of human rights—killings, abductions, torture and severe ill-treatment—committed between 1960 and 1994 by agents of the apartheid state and by members of the liberation movements; amnesty required full disclosure and a political motive. Its failures were real: reparations reached victims late and fell short of what the Commission recommended, and few of those refused amnesty, or who never applied, were pros-

ecuted. The contrast survives these qualifications. Even an imperfect exchange of amnesty for truth requires the perpetrator to speak; the Council required him to forget.

4.3 *Renan's Republic*

In his 1882 lecture *Qu'est-ce qu'une nation?* Ernest Renan argued that forgetting, and even historical error, is an essential factor in the making of a nation, and that every French citizen must have forgotten the massacre of Saint Bartholomew and the massacres of the Midi in the thirteenth century. The Republic of *KOTOR* survives by such forgetting. It must not remember that its savior from the Mandalorians became its destroyer, nor that its present champion is the same person. The light-side ending's ceremony, a deliberate echo of the medal ceremony that closes the 1977 film, is a Renanian rite. It commemorates by forgetting: it honors a hero whose true name the Republic cannot pronounce. Revan is the Republic's Saint Bartholomew.

Borges dramatized this rite with uncanny precision. In "Theme of the Traitor and the Hero" (1944) a historian discovers that Fergus Kilpatrick, the martyred leader of an Irish conspiracy, was its traitor, and that his comrades, rather than expose him, staged his execution as a heroic assassination so that his death would kindle the rising. Having uncovered the deception, the historian publishes a book in the hero's honor and keeps the secret. The Republic's ceremony is Kilpatrick's funeral inverted—the traitor is not killed but rewritten—and the historian's complicity names the temptation criticism faces whenever a commemoration is more useful than the truth.

4.4 *The Grand Inquisitor and the Choice Architect*

In Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* (Book V, ch. 5) the Grand Inquisitor reproaches Christ for burdening humanity with freedom and boasts that the Church has corrected his work by relieving people of that burden in exchange for bread, miracle, mystery and authority. It is tempting to cast the Council as Inquisitor, but the analogy fails at the decisive point. The Council does not abolish the protagonist's freedom. It abolishes the memory that would condition that freedom and then arranges the environment in which it will be exercised: Jedi training, a curated company of companions, an intimate bond with Bastila, a quest engineered to retrace Revan's steps. This is not despotism but what Richard Thaler and Cass Sunstein called *libertarian paternalism*—the preservation of choice combined with the deliberate design of the "choice architecture"

that makes some choices likelier than others (*Nudge*, 2008). The Council is a choice architect.

Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) supplies the antithesis. The Ludovico Technique preserves Alex's memory and abolishes his capacity to choose, and the prison chaplain objects that one who can no longer choose is no longer a man in the full sense. The Council inverts Ludovico: it abolishes memory and preserves choice. The inversion does not exculpate. The chaplain's objection merely changes form: a person who cannot remember what he is choosing against cannot fully choose. The Council wagers on freedom while instrumentalizing it, and that wager is the most modern element in the game.

4.5 *The Noetic Continuum*

The light side's ordinary repertoire includes the manipulation of minds. The "mind trick" has been a Jedi signature since the first film; in *KOTOR* it appears as Force powers that cloud or dominate the minds of others and as the Persuade skill, which opens dialogue options that let the protagonist bend wills. The game seldom treats such manipulation as dark; in a good cause it counts as technique. Kant's formula of humanity—so act that you treat humanity, in your own person or in another's, always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means (*Groundwork*, Ak. 4:429)—makes the bypassing of rational agency the paradigm of wrong. Measured by that formula, the difference between the mind trick and the Council's refabrication is one of degree and duration, not of kind. Both replace the agent's reasons with the manipulator's ends. The noetic continuum runs unbroken from a guard waved aside to a Dark Lord rewritten. The Council's act is not a deviation from Jedi practice but its limit case.

The continuum extends to the conduct of the war. Bastila Shan matters to both sides because of Battle Meditation, a Force discipline by which she strengthens the resolve and coordination of allied forces and erodes the will of the enemy across an entire engagement. It is the Republic's most valuable strategic asset, and it is the manipulation of minds at the scale of fleets. Malak blockaded Taris to trap her and destroyed it rather than let her escape, and later captured and turned her, because he wanted that power for himself. Republic and Sith disagree about whose minds Battle Meditation should bend, not about whether minds may be bent.

The franchise itself supplies the gloss. In the 1977 film, Owen Lars instructs his nephew to have a newly purchased droid's memory erased, adding: "That'll be the end of it. It belongs to us now." Erasure is appropriation; the wiped mind becomes property. The Council performs upon Revan the procedure the franchise reserves for droids. Within the game, HK-47—built by Revan, as the

gradual repair of his memory core discloses—serves as the protagonist's mechanical double: an instrument whose past has been locked away, recovering by degrees the knowledge of whose instrument it is.

4.6 *Law-Making Violence*

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) holds that all violence used as a means is either law-making or law-preserving; that the police combine the two in a spectral mixture; and that against this mythic violence stands a divine violence that destroys law rather than founding it. The Council's act is mythic, law-making violence. It posits a new legal subject—a person with a name, a history and an allegiance—out of a captured body. And as Benjamin argued that founding violence persists in the institutions that preserve law, the Jedi, peacekeepers and quasi-police of the Republic, carry the founding violence of their order into their everyday manipulations of mind. Divine violence, which Benjamin associates with the annihilation of a mythic order as such, has its only analogue at the game's end, in the destruction of the Star Forge, examined in Chapter VII.

4.7 *Leviathan*

Hobbes named the commonwealth after the sea-monster of Job 41, whose Vulgate verse—there is no power on earth to be compared with him—crowns the frontispiece of *Leviathan* (1651). He made the sovereign judge of which opinions and doctrines may be taught (ch. 18), and in the Latin version of 1668 he condensed his jurisprudence into the maxim that authority, not truth, makes law (*auctoritas, non veritas, facit legem*, ch. 26). The protagonist of *KOTOR* learns who they are aboard a ship called *Leviathan*, from the mouth of a usurping sovereign. The truth of identity is delivered as an act of authority, and Malak's declaration competes with the Council's fabrication: both are sovereign pronouncements about who the subject is. The protagonist's task after the *Leviathan* is to decide whether identity is to be received from any sovereign at all.

Hobbes's state of nature, a war of every one against every one in which life is solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short (ch. 13), is staged on Taris, where the Lower City's swoop gangs, the criminal Exchange and the outcasts of the Undercity form a Hobbesian substrate beneath an occupied Republic world. Saul Karath—once Carth Onasi's mentor, now a Sith admiral, responsible for the bombardment of Telos that killed Carth's wife—embodies Arendt's functionary: no dark-side stigmata, only competence placed at the service of devastation. The *Leviathan* is captained by banality and visited by sovereignty.

4.8 *Revan and Malak: Power, Violence, Virtù*

The game repeatedly contrasts Revan's conduct of the war with Malak's. Revan, characters remark, sought to take the Republic intact; Malak razes. He ordered the orbital bombardment of Taris, which destroyed its cities and killed its population, in order to kill a single Jedi; it is the game's founding atrocity. Hannah Arendt distinguished power, the human ability to act in concert, which belongs to a group and is sustained by its consent, from violence, which is instrumental and can destroy power but never create it; where one rules absolutely, the other is absent (*On Violence*, 1970). Malak's bombardment is violence as the confession of powerlessness.

Machiavelli distinguished cruelty well used, applied once and out of necessity and then converted as far as possible to the subjects' benefit, from cruelty badly used, which grows with time (*The Prince*, ch. VIII); a prince unable to be both loved and feared should prefer to be feared, but must above all avoid being hated (ch. XVII). Revan's reputed strategy is cruelty well used; Malak's is cruelty badly used, and he becomes hated. Weber's typology of authority completes the contrast. Charismatic authority rests on followers' recognition of extraordinary personal qualities and faces the problem of its own routinization (*Economy and Society*, 1922). Revan's charisma, which drew Jedi and soldiers into the Mandalorian Wars and held fleets together, does not transfer to the usurper, whose rule devolves into terror. Thucydides gave the logic of such terror its classic statement in the Athenian envoys' claim at Melos that the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must (V.89); Melos was annihilated. Taris is the game's Melos. The Mytilenean debate, in which Athens rescinded a decree of mass execution the day after passing it (III.36–49), is the road Malak never considered.

4.9 *The Mandalorian Wars and the Tragedy of Responsibility*

The origin of Revan's fall lies in the Mandalorian Wars, which Revan and Malak entered with their followers against the Council's counsel of patience. Max Weber's "Politics as a Vocation" (1919) distinguishes the ethic of conviction, which does right and leaves the outcome to God, from the ethic of responsibility, which answers for the foreseeable consequences of action. Whoever takes up politics, Weber warns—that is, power and force as means—contracts with diabolical powers; the early Christians knew the world to be governed by demons. The dark side is Weber's diabolical powers rendered cosmological. Revan's fall is the price of political responsibility: he entered the war, won it, and was trans-

formed by its means. The Council's purity is the ethic of conviction, and its abstention left the Outer Rim to burn.

Michael Walzer's analysis of "dirty hands" (1973) holds that a good politician may be obliged to do wrong and ought to feel the guilt of it; his doctrine of "supreme emergency" (*Just and Unjust Wars*, 1977) permits the overriding of the war convention when a community faces imminent catastrophe. Sartre's *Les Mains sales* (1948) stages the confrontation as drama: Hoederer, who admits that his hands are dirty to the elbows, mocks the purism of the young Hugo. The Council is Hugo; Revan is Hoederer—before he became something worse. The *Gītā* offers a final measure. Arjuna is commanded to fight without attachment to the fruits of action; Revan fought with attachment, to victory and perhaps to dominion. *KOTOR* leaves undecided whether Revan fell because he fought or because he fought for the wrong reasons; its sequel would turn that ambiguity into a thesis (Chapter VIII).

Conrad supplies the geography of the fall. In *Heart of Darkness* (1899) Kurtz, the most gifted emissary of a civilizing enterprise, travels upriver to the edge of the known and is found ruling as a god over the people he was sent to improve; Marlow, sent to retrieve him, recognizes in Kurtz a possibility of his own. Revan and Malak pursued the defeated Mandalorians into the Unknown Regions and returned at the head of a Sith fleet. *KOTOR*'s protagonist occupies both of Conrad's positions at once—Marlow on the trail of the Star Maps, Kurtz at its end—so that the journey upriver ends not in an encounter with another but in a recognition of the self.

4.10 *The Colonial Unconscious of the Republic*

The Republic is lethocratic not only toward Revan but toward its peripheries. The Czerka Corporation operates across the game's worlds as a Republic enterprise: on Kashyyyk it buys Wookiee slaves from the usurping chieftain Chuundar; on Tatooine it extracts minerals and pays bounties on the Sand People. Frantz Fanon's account of the national bourgeoisie as the intermediary between colonial capital and the colonized (*The Wretched of the Earth*, 1961, ch. 3) describes Chuundar precisely. The Jedi are silent. The Republic's peace reaches its margins as extraction—Calgacus's desolation called peace—and the Sith Code's claim that peace is a lie acquires empirical warrant. Yet the Sith do not liberate; on occupied Taris, segregation and quarantine harden under their rule. The light-sided protagonist's interventions—freeing the Wookiees, brokering terms with the Sand People—constitute an anamnetic counter-practice, attention to precisely what the Republic forgets, whose ethics Chapter IX reconstructs.

4.11 *Conclusion*

The Council's act is at once a sovereign exception, an amnesty-as-amnesia, an exercise of choice architecture, a law-making violence and the limit case of a continuum of mental manipulation that the light side practices daily. The *Leviathan* is the site where sovereignty and truth collide; the contrast of Revan and Malak is the contrast of power and violence; the Mandalorian Wars are a Weberian tragedy of responsibility; and the Republic's neglect of its peripheries extends its lethocracy from one mind to whole peoples. Lethocracy is not the moral failure of a few masters. It is the political form of the light side. Chapter V turns to the subject this form produced.



Part Three

The Subject

Chapter

V

The Revenant Subject: Personal Identity after Revan

5.1 "Am I Revan?"

5.2 Locke: The Forensic Person

5.3 Butler, Reid, and Quasi-Memory

5.4 Parfit: Identity Is Not What Matters

5.5 Williams's Asymmetry and the Animal

5.6 Narrative, Orientation, and Bad Faith

5.7 Non-Self: Anattā and the Bundle

5.8 The Revenant Subject and the Reprise Criterion

5.9 Mirrors and Doubles

5.10 Comparanda: A Typology of Revenant Fictions

5.11 Conclusion

5.1 *"Am I Revan?"*

The reveal turns into lived predicament the question philosophers pose as thought experiment. The protagonist has the same body as Revan and the same presence in the Force—the signature by which Malak and Bastila recognize the protagonist—but a largely discontinuous psychology: memory erased, character reshaped by months of new experience, values potentially inverted. The question "Is the protagonist Revan?" has at least three senses: metaphysical (numerical identity), forensic (responsibility and desert), and practical (what the protagonist should care about and answer for). Each major theory of personal identity answers differently, and *KOTOR* functions as a natural experiment that sorts them.

What the protagonist would have to answer for should be stated exactly. After leading Jedi volunteers and Republic forces to victory over the Mandalorians, Revan, with Malak as apprentice, returned from the Unknown Regions at the head of a Sith fleet and, together with Republic forces that had gone over to the dark side, invaded Republic space, seizing worlds and drawing Jedi to the Sith. HK-47's restored memories record assassinations carried out on Revan's orders. The bombardment of Taris was Malak's order and the bombardment of Telos was carried out by Saul Karath's fleet, but both belong to a war Revan began. The forensic question is whether these deeds can be imputed to the protagonist.

5.2 *Locke: The Forensic Person*

In the chapter "Of Identity and Diversity" added to the second edition of the *Essay* (1694), Locke defines a person as "a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing, in different times and places" (II.xxvii.9), and extends personal identity exactly as far back as consciousness can reach. If the soul of a prince, carrying his consciousness, entered the body of a cobbler, the resulting man would be the prince (§15). "Person" is a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit (§26). Human courts punish the drunkard for what he did while drunk because the fact can be proved and the lack of consciousness cannot; but at the Last Judgment, Locke holds, no one shall be made to answer for what he knows nothing of (§22).

Locke's verdict on the protagonist is unambiguous: not Revan, and not justly punishable for Revan's crimes. This vindicates the Council's exculpatory hope while convicting it from another side. If the protagonist is not Revan, the Council has not reformed Revan; it has extinguished one person and made another—a Lockean execution by amnesia, performed without trial. Locke's theory, more-

over, renders the protagonist's repentance unintelligible. One cannot repent what one did not do. Yet the light path makes the acceptance of Revan's guilt—before Carth, before the companions, before the dead of two wars—its central ethical gesture. The game's ethics exceed Locke's metaphysics.

5.3 *Butler, Reid, and Quasi-Memory*

Joseph Butler objected that consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity: one can remember only one's own experiences (1736). Thomas Reid's brave officer, flogged as a boy for robbing an orchard, later took a standard from the enemy as a young officer and still later became a general; the general remembers the standard, the young officer remembered the flogging, but the general has forgotten the flogging—so that on Locke's principles the general both is and is not the boy (*Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*, 1785, III.6). The protagonist presents a Reid case in reverse: no memory of Revan, yet fragmentary visions of Revan's past, above all the vision on Dantooine of Revan and Malak discovering the Star Map.

Sydney Shoemaker introduced *quasi-memory* to break Butler's circle: a memory-like state caused in the appropriate way by a past experience that need not have been one's own (1970). The protagonist's visions arrive through the bond with Bastila, and their provenance is undecidable within the game: Revan's memories resurfacing, Bastila's memories transmitted—she witnessed Revan's capture—or Force-visions with no owner. That undecidability makes them paradigmatic quasi-memories. They are also observer memories. Cognitive psychology distinguishes field memories, retrieved from one's original vantage, from observer memories, in which one sees oneself from outside, a perspective associated with temporal distance and self-change (Nigro and Neisser 1983). The protagonist sees Revan from outside, as a figure in a scene. Ricoeur's title *Oneself as Another* names this mode of recollection exactly.

5.4 *Parfit: Identity Is Not What Matters*

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) analyzes personal identity in terms of Relation R—psychological connectedness (direct links of memory, intention and persisting belief and desire) and continuity (overlapping chains of strong connectedness)—and argues through cases of teletransportation, fission and gradual replacement that identity is not what matters in survival: R is. In many cases the question whether a future person will be me is empty, since once the physical and psychological facts are known there is no further fact to discover. The protagonist's connectedness with Revan is near zero; continuity survives

only through the brain and residual dispositions—martial skill, aptitude in the Force, perhaps temperament. On Parfit's view the question "Is the protagonist Revan?" approaches emptiness, and what matters, the degree of R, is low.

Parfit applies this directly to desert, arguing that when psychological connectedness is weak, a person may deserve less for the crimes of a past self (*Reasons and Persons*, ch. 15). His "Nineteenth Century Russian," a young idealist who foresees losing his ideals and asks his wife to hold him to his present commitments, inverts the protagonist's case: there the present self binds a future self it regards as another; here the Republic must decide whether to bind a present self to a past it does not recognize. Parfit reported that his view was liberating—as though the walls of a glass tunnel had vanished—and noted its affinity with the Buddha's teaching (Appendix J). *KOTOR* withholds that liberation. Companions and polity alike refuse to treat the question as empty; they want an answer.

5.5 *Williams's Asymmetry and the Animal*

Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) describes a procedure in which two persons exchange psychological contents and asks which resulting body each, beforehand, should wish to be rewarded and which tortured. Described as an exchange, the case invites identification with one's psychology. Redescribed—"you will be tortured tomorrow, and beforehand your memories will be replaced with another's"—it invites fear, implicating the continuity of the body. Our identifications, Williams concludes, are unstable under redescription. The reveal is Williams's second framing applied in retrospect: the protagonist learns that the body they inhabit performed acts they do not remember, and that its future may hold the reprisals those acts earned. The dread that protagonist and player feel is Williams's intuition at work.

Eric Olson's animalism holds that we are human animals whose persistence conditions are biological, so that psychology is irrelevant to numerical identity (*The Human Animal*, 1997). On this view the protagonist is the same organism as Revan and therefore Revan. Olson concedes that what matters practically may diverge from identity. *KOTOR* stages that divergence with unusual purity: metaphysical identity (animalism: yes) and forensic personhood (Locke: no) come apart, and the game's ethics live in the gap between them.

The concept of moral luck exposes a further difficulty. Bernard Williams and Thomas Nagel argued that moral assessment is pervasively exposed to factors beyond the agent's control; Nagel distinguished, among others, resultant luck in how things turn out, circumstantial luck in the situations one faces, and constitutive luck in the kind of person one is (Williams, "Moral Luck," 1976; Nagel,

"Moral Luck," 1976). The light-side protagonist is constitutively lucky to an extraordinary degree. The disposition from which their redemptive choices flow was installed by the Council's intervention; a Revan never captured, or captured by Malak, would not have had it. If constitutive luck cannot be credited to the agent, the protagonist's goodness looks borrowed. The Reprise Criterion answers by relocating merit from the possession of a disposition to the assumption of answerability (§5.8): what belongs to the protagonist is not the character the Council supplied but what they do with the past the Council concealed.

5.6 *Narrative, Orientation, and Bad Faith*

Alasdair MacIntyre locates the unity of a human life in the unity of a narrative quest and holds that to be the subject of such a narrative is to be accountable for the actions and experiences that compose a narratable life (*After Virtue*, 1981, ch. 15). The protagonist's narrative was falsified; the reveal ruptures the unity of the quest; the light path re-narrates by integrating Revan's life as prologue. Paul Ricoeur distinguishes *idem*-identity—sameness, permanence in time, the identity of character, body and habit—from *ipse*-identity—selfhood, the constancy exemplified by keeping one's word despite change (*Oneself as Another*, 1990, Studies 5–6). In the protagonist *idem* is fractured, the body persisting while character is remade, and *ipse* becomes the site at which identity can be reconstituted. The light-side Revan becomes Revan again not by recovering *idem* but by assuming *ipse*: I am the one who answers for Revan.

Marya Schechtman's narrative self-constitution view holds that persons constitute their identities by forming autobiographical narratives subject to an articulation constraint and a reality constraint, the latter requiring coherence with basic facts and with others' interpretations (*The Constitution of Selves*, 1996). The protagonist's self-narrative fails the reality constraint before the reveal without the protagonist knowing it; afterward it must be rearticulated. Galen Strawson's distinction between Diachronic selves, who experience themselves as persisting through a life, and Episodic selves, who do not, and his denial that narrativity is a condition of a good life ("Against Narrativity," 2004), describe the alternative the Council forced upon Revan: an imposed Episodicity. The companions insist on Diachronicity.

Charles Taylor argued that identity is defined by orientation in a space of moral questions—that knowing who one is amounts to knowing one's position in that space (*Sources of the Self*, 1989). The reveal shifts the protagonist's question from *who* to *where*. The interface had always asked the latter, through the alignment axis; the reveal announces that the former already has an answer the protagonist did not choose, and that only the latter remains open. Sartre's anal-

ysis of bad faith specifies the two ways of failing that openness. The for-itself "is what it is not and is not what it is"; bad faith denies either facticity, treating oneself as pure transcendence, or transcendence, treating oneself as a thing fixed by one's past (*Being and Nothingness*, 1943, Part I, ch. 2). "I am not Revan at all" denies facticity. "I am Revan, therefore I am Sith"—the rhetoric of Malak, of Bastila on the Star Forge, and of the dark path's summons to return to one's true self—denies transcendence. The authentic response holds both: I am Revan in the mode of not being Revan.

Two further vocabularies make the same diagnosis. Heidegger called the condition of finding oneself already delivered over to a situation one did not choose thrownness (*Geworfenheit*; *Being and Time* §§29, 38). The protagonist wakes on a burning ship, thrown into a war; the reveal discloses that the thrownness runs deeper, into a past and not only a world. Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) distinguishes the despair of not willing to be oneself from the despair of defiantly willing to be oneself—a self of one's own construction that refuses the power that established it. The first is the protagonist who will not acknowledge Revan; the second is the protagonist who takes up Revan's mantle as a self-made Dark Lord. Kierkegaard's remedy for both is to will to be oneself while resting transparently in what grounds the self; in the light path's secular register, to accept the unchosen past without either disowning it or enthroning it.

Kierkegaard supplies the positive form of that response. In the second part of *Either/Or* (1843), in the letter its author titles "The Balance between the Esthetic and the Ethical in the Development of the Personality," Judge William describes the ethical self as choosing itself in its full concreteness, including what it did not author, and as repenting itself back into itself, into its family and its race, until it finds itself in God. Repentance here is not regret for what one did but the appropriation of a history one did not choose. It is the movement of the light path.

5.7 *Non-Self: Anattā and the Bundle*

In the *Milindapañha* the monk Nāgasena tells King Milinda that his own name, like the word "chariot," designates an assemblage of parts rather than an abiding self (*anattā*); Hume found, on introspection, only a bundle of perceptions (*Treatise* I.iv.6); Parfit aligned his reductionism explicitly with the Buddhist view. The irony for *KOTOR* is sharp. The Jedi's metaphysics, drawn in part from Buddhist sources, should welcome the dissolution of Revan's self. Yet the Council's strategy presupposes a substantial self beneath the erased memory, a Revan whose powers and knowledge of the route persist and can be redirected.

The Council preaches non-attachment and practices an essentialism of the soul, treating the self as dispensable in doctrine and indispensable in strategy.

5.8 *The Revenant Subject and the Reprise Criterion*

Freud's "Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through" (1914) observes that the patient does not remember what has been forgotten and repressed but acts it out, reproducing it not as memory but as action, repeating without knowing that he repeats; the analyst's task is to convert repetition into remembering through working-through (*Durcharbeiten*). *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) generalizes the observation into a compulsion to repeat. The protagonist's quest is an acting-out: it re-traverses Revan's route to the Star Maps—Dantooine, Tatooine, Kashyyyk, Manaan, Korriban—repeating as action what cannot be recalled as memory.

The Council functions as a perverse analyst. It understands the repetition and exploits it, steering the acting-out toward its strategic object, the Star Forge, rather than toward working-through. The bond with Bastila is the transference. Freud insisted that the analyst must neither gratify nor flee the patient's love but use it in the service of the cure ("Observations on Transference-Love," 1915); Bastila's attachment, and her own answering love, break the analytic frame. The *Leviathan* is the interpretation delivered at last—by the wrong analyst, with the wrong intent. Freud had a name for interpretations blurted without preparation to a patient unready to bear them: "wild" psycho-analysis (1910). Malak is the wild analyst of the Old Republic.

Three further sources complete the concept. Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) holds that repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. The protagonist recollects forward, traversing Revan's past by moving into their own future. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) describes the specter as that which begins by coming back—a *revenant*—and replaces ontology with a hauntology for figures neither present nor absent. "Revan" sounds the *revenant*, the one who returns, and *revanche*, the retaking; the protagonist is haunted by a ghost who is themselves. Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) holds that repetition is not the return of the same but the production of difference, a thesis Borges had dramatized in "Pierre Menard, Author of the *Quixote*" (1939), whose verbatim rewriting of Cervantes is a different and richer text because written in a different time. The protagonist's journey is identical to Revan's in route and different in meaning. Nietzsche's plastic power—the capacity to incorporate the past and heal its wounds (§2.4)—names the faculty such repetition requires, and Stephen Darwall's account of moral

obligation as constituted by second-personal reasons, claims addressed by one person to another under presupposed mutual accountability (*The Second-Person Standpoint*, 2006), names the medium in which answerability lives.

From these sources I formulate the identity condition of the Revenant Subject.

The Reprise Criterion. A subject X at t_2 is the revenant of a subject Y at t_1 if and only if:

1. *Re-traversal*: X's agency re-traces, in substantial part, the world-line of Y's projects—its places, relations and quests;
2. *Non-recollection*: the re-traversal proceeds without autobiographical memory of Y's experiences, though quasi-memories may be present;
3. *Difference*: at the nodes where Y chose, X chooses, and X's choices are evaluatively open, so that X may repeat or diverge;
4. *Answerability*: X accepts as addressed to X the second-personal claims of those whom Y wronged, and responds to them in the first person.

The criterion is neutral on numerical identity; animalism may be true. It supersedes Locke's forensic personhood with an answerability that does not require memory. Its advantages are four. It renders repentance intelligible, since the fourth condition establishes the relation within which repentance operates. It explains why the dark ending reads as a return, the third condition resolved toward repetition, and the light ending as a re-founding, the same condition resolved toward difference. It explains why the companions' responses—Carth's resentment, Canderous's indifference, HK-47's delight, Jolee's wry acceptance—bear on who the protagonist is, since identity in the revenant sense is partly constituted by the address of others. And it generalizes beyond fiction to profound amnesia, radical conversion and transitional justice, wherever persons or polities must answer for pasts they do not remember or recognize. Its limit case is refusal of the fourth condition: a subject who declines all address remains Revan's organic successor but not Revan's revenant. Strawson's Episodic exit is coherent in principle, but *KOTOR* does not offer it as a stable option; the narrative compels address.

Kant had already confronted the structure the criterion formalizes. In *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason* (1793) he argued that the propensity to evil is radical, rooted in the supreme maxim of the will, so that conversion cannot be a gradual reform of conduct but must be a revolution in disposition, a kind of rebirth or new creation (Ak. 6:47). He then posed the problem of the debt: the converted person began from evil, and that original guilt cannot be erased by subsequent good conduct (Ak. 6:72). His solution is that the person who undergoes conversion is physically the same individual, liable to punishment, yet morally another, and that the new self takes upon itself, as suffering

freely accepted in the course of conversion, the penalty owed by the old (Ak. 6:73–74). Kant's new man bearing the debt of the old is the revenant answering for the predecessor. What Kant could not imagine was a conversion imposed from without. The Council produced the rebirth; the protagonist must make it their own by assuming the debt.

5.9 *Mirrors and Doubles*

The game surrounds its protagonist with doubles that refract the predicament. HK-47, whose memory has been locked and who rediscovers his maker by degrees, is the comic double: his loyalty survives his amnesia, and he wants the old master back. Juhani, the Cathar apprentice on Dantooine, believes that she killed her master Quatra in a fit of anger and has fled into the dark side; Quatra is alive. The chiasmus is exact. Revan's crimes happened and are not remembered; Juhani's crime is remembered and did not happen. Both are redeemed through recognition—the protagonist reveals to Juhani that her guilt is unfounded, as the protagonist must learn that their own innocence is unfounded. Bastila, whose name echoes the fortress-prison of the old regime, is the jailer of the secret who becomes Malak's prisoner; she saved Revan's life after Malak's betrayal, and the protagonist may save hers on the Star Forge, completing a reciprocity of rescue. Malak, whose name means "messenger" or "angel," is the angel of a strange annunciation: he announces not a birth but a prior identity.

5.10 *Comparanda: A Typology of Revenant Fictions*

KOTOR's predicament belongs to a family of speculative and philosophical fictions that can be sorted into five types.

The first is the *detective as culprit*. Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus* is its archetype; William Hjortsberg's *Falling Angel* (1978) and Alan Parker's *Angel Heart* (1987), in which the investigator Harry Angel discovers that he is the vanished singer Johnny Favorite, who bargained with the devil; *Silent Hill 2* (Konami, 2001), whose protagonist's search for his dead wife reveals that he killed her; and Dennis Lehane's *Shutter Island* (2003) are its modern instances. Philip K. Dick's "Impostor" (1953) gives the type its most violent form: a man accused of being a robot replica concealing a bomb proves his innocence until he finds the real man's corpse, and the recognition detonates the bomb—anagnorisis as explosion.

The second is *institutional overwriting*. In Alfred Bester's *The Demolished Man* (1953) the penalty for murder is "Demolition," the dismantling and rebuilding

of the criminal's personality. In Dick's "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966) and Paul Verhoeven's *Total Recall* (1990), the agent Hauser's identity has been overwritten with that of the laborer Quaid as part of a scheme, and Quaid chooses to remain Quaid. In Dick's *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) an agency destroys an undercover agent's mind and delivers the husk into the organization it wishes to infiltrate—an institution consuming a self as an instrument. *Blade Runner* (1982) and Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) supply implanted memories as the substrate of selves that are no less real for being authored.

The third is *self-arranged forgetting*. In Dick's "Paycheck" (1953) an engineer whose memory of two years has been erased discovers that his former self left him an envelope of trinkets on which his survival depends; in Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) a man without short-term memory is steered by notes he left himself, including notes that deceive; in Gene Wolfe's *Soldier of the Mist* (1986) a soldier who forgets each day reconstructs himself from his own written record. The fourth is *shadow-naming*: in Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) Ged pursues the shadow he loosed upon the world and defeats it by naming it with his own name. The fifth is *serial selves*: in *Planescape: Torment* an immortal confronts the debris of his former incarnations under the question of what can change the nature of a man, and in Roger Zelazny's *Nine Princes in Amber* (1970) Corwin wakes amnesiac on Earth to discover that he is a prince of Amber whose exile has made him a better man than his former self.

KOTOR is distinctive in combining the first and second types—the detective discovers himself the culprit, and an institution engineered the discovery—and in adding a ludic dimension absent from all its comparanda: the player co-authored the false self (Chapter VI). Its closest analogues are *Total Recall*, with its choice to remain the overwritten self, and *Earthsea*, with its integration by naming. The light ending fuses them: the protagonist accepts the name, as Ged does, while refusing the self that bore it, as Quaid does.

5.11 *Conclusion*

Locke exculpates the protagonist but cannot account for repentance. Parfit empties the question, but the narrative refuses emptiness. Williams and Olson secure bodily identity but sever it from responsibility. Narrative theories supply accountability and *ipse*, and Sartre and Kierkegaard supply the modalities in which an unchosen past may be authentically assumed. The Reprise Criterion integrates these results: identity as repetition under difference, completed by answerability. The Revenant Subject is not a curiosity of science fantasy but a model for agents—persons and polities alike—who must answer for pasts they cannot remember.

Chapter

VI

Hexis, Ledger, and Mask: The Procedural Ethics of Alignment

6.1 The Meter as Moral Ontology

6.2 Aristotle and the Counting of Acts

6.3 Scalar Monism and Diegetic Dualism

6.4 The Ledger: Moral Bookkeeping and Its Discontents

6.5 Persuasion and the Ethics of Rhetoric

6.6 The Ludic Legislator

6.7 Save and Load: Amnesty and the Ring of Gyges

6.8 Mask and Persona

6.9 Conclusion: The Third Mnemonic Regime

6.1 *The Meter as Moral Ontology*

The alignment system of *KOTOR* registers a value that moves between a light and a dark pole in response to designated choices—dialogue options and actions flagged by the designers as one or the other. Its consequences are mechanical and narrative: Force powers aligned with the protagonist's standing cost less to use and opposed powers cost more; the protagonist's appearance changes; certain companions respond; the endings branch. The meter is not a feedback device appended to a story. It is the game's theory of moral character, executed as code. It has three properties, each encoding a philosophical commitment. It is *cumulative*: character is the running sum of acts. It is *scalar*: there is one axis. It is *public*, at least to the player, who reads it on a gauge. This chapter examines each commitment and then turns to the position the system assigns the player.

6.2 *Aristotle and the Counting of Acts*

Aristotle derives the name of moral virtue, *ēthikē*, from habit, *ethos*, and holds that we become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.1, 1103a14–b25). The meter is habituation made visible: dispositions accrue through deeds. But Aristotle adds at once that acts in accordance with virtue are not done justly or temperately unless the agent acts in a certain condition: knowing what he does, choosing the act and choosing it for its own sake, and acting from a firm and unchanging state, a *hexis* (II.4, 1105a28–33). The meter registers only the external act. It cannot register knowledge, since a player may select the light option for its reward; it cannot register *prohairesis*, choice of the act for its own sake; and it cannot register a stable disposition, since the gauge swings with each flagged choice. It counts the acts of a *hexis* it cannot see.

The doctrine of the mean exposes a deeper inversion. Virtue, Aristotle holds, is a state concerned with choice, lying in a mean relative to us, determined by reason as the person of practical wisdom would determine it (II.6, 1106b36–1107a2). On *KOTOR*'s line the extremes are the states the system rewards most richly—the purest alignments purchase the deepest discounts—while the middle is neither punished nor honored but merely uncommitted. Excellence lies at the poles and the mean is mediocrity, the exact reverse of the Aristotelian scheme. An Aristotelian would diagnose the light pole, untempered by *phronēsis*, as a vice of excess, a rigorism that becomes its own failing; the Council is its portrait. Nor can the meter represent *akrasia* (Book VII): the agent who chooses

wrongly while knowing better and the agent who chooses wrongly from settled conviction receive identical entries.

6.3 *Scalar Monism and Diegetic Dualism*

The fiction presents light and dark as ontologically opposed powers, a Manichaean dualism with Augustinian hesitations (§2.1). The code computes a single magnitude. Light and dark are positions on one continuum, commensurable and mutually offsetting; a sum of dark acts can be cancelled by a sum of light. This is a monism—one substance moving in two directions—and its closest philosophical articulation is Spinoza's. There is one substance (*Ethics* I, P14); good and evil indicate nothing positive in things considered in themselves but are modes of thinking formed by comparison (IV, Preface). Spinoza titles the fourth part of the *Ethics* "Of Human Bondage, or the Powers of the Affects": bondage is subjection to passive affects, and freedom comes through adequate understanding, since an affect that is a passion ceases to be a passion as soon as we form a clear and distinct idea of it (V, P3).

Spinoza thus inverts the Sith Code, for passion is the chain and not the key, and rebukes the Jedi Code, for affect is not abolished but transformed into activity. The code beneath the Codes stands closer to Spinoza, and to the heterodoxies of Jolee Bindo and Kreia examined in Chapter VIII, than to either diegetic doctrine. The game's arithmetic testifies quietly against its theology: light and dark are made of the same stuff.

6.4 *The Ledger: Moral Bookkeeping and Its Discontents*

The meter has a history outside games. Benjamin Franklin's *Autobiography* (composed 1771–1790) recounts his "bold and arduous project of arriving at moral perfection": thirteen virtues, a small book with a page for each, a column for each day, and a black spot for each fault. Weber made Franklin the exemplary voice of the spirit of capitalism and traced to Puritan practice a methodical bookkeeping of the moral life, in which diaries recorded sins and graces as entries in an account (*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, 1904–1905). The medieval treasury of merit, and its commercialization in the indulgences against which Luther posted his theses in 1517, supplies an older form: merit as transferable credit. *KOTOR*'s meter is a ledger, and it permits arbitrage. Dark deeds are offset by light; redemption is a balance restored. The theology it implies is not repentance but compensation.

Kant's shopkeeper, who gives correct change to an inexperienced customer because honesty is good for business, acts in conformity with duty but not from

duty, and his act has no moral worth (*Groundwork*, Ak. 4:397). The meter cannot distinguish the honest shopkeeper from the prudent one; worse, it makes every shopkeeper prudent, since every light act is paid. Experimental psychology supplies an empirical correlate in the finding that extrinsic reward can undermine intrinsic interest in an activity (Lepper, Greene and Nisbett 1973). Miguel Sicart's critique of moral meters as the conversion of ethical play into resource management (Sicart 2009) is thus anticipated by Kant and corroborated by psychology. The irony is pointed: the Council treats Revan merely as a means and so fails Kant's test at the level of story, while the meter, its procedural counterpart, makes the player a Benthamite calculator at the level of play.

6.5 *Persuasion and the Ethics of Rhetoric*

The Persuade skill and the mind-affecting Force powers open dialogue routes otherwise closed, and the game's economy rewards investment in them as efficient. Plato's *Gorgias* distinguishes rhetoric, a knack of flattery that produces belief without knowledge, from the genuine art that aims at the good of the soul (463a–465d). The game's rhetoric alternates between flattery and force and rarely approaches dialectic. The noetic continuum of §4.5 reappears here as a skill tree: the protagonist's advancement includes the acquisition of the power to bypass other minds' reasons, and the light-sided protagonist is its chief beneficiary. The continuity between the virtuous Jedi's ordinary technique and the Council's extraordinary act is thus built into the progression system.

6.6 *The Ludic Legislator*

The game begins with character creation. The player chooses sex, face, class (Soldier, Scout or Scoundrel), attributes, skills, feats and a name. In light of the reveal, this screen is the scene of the Council's crime. The player designs a fabricated identity for a person who already exists: selects a face that will prove to have been Revan's, a class that will prove to have been a cover, a name that the fiction will override. Genre convention presents character creation as authorship from nothing; the reveal shows it to have been overwriting. The player has occupied the Council's seat from the first screen. This is the sense of the term *ludic legislator*: the player as author of the noble lie.

Theories of the avatar sharpen the point. James Paul Gee distinguished the player's real-world identity, the character's virtual identity, and a projective identity, the player's project for the character (Gee 2003). The reveal destabilizes all three. The virtual identity proves false; the projective identity—the kind of person the player wished the character to be—turns out to have been

imposed upon a prior person. Bob Rehak read the avatar through Lacan's mirror stage (1949), in which the infant jubilantly identifies with a unified image that anticipates a mastery it does not possess (Rehak 2003); the reveal cracks that mirror to show another face behind the reflection. Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* (1979) addresses its reader in the second person, and *KOTOR*'s reveal is a second-person address of the same kind. Louis Althusser's account of interpellation (1970) supplies its structure. The individual hailed in the street—"Hey, you there!"—turns around and, by that conversion, becomes a subject, recognizing that the hail was addressed to him; and individuals, Althusser adds, are always already subjects. Malak's hail interpellates; the player turns; the protagonist was always already Revan. In Lacanian terms, "Revan" is a quilting point (*point de capiton*), a master signifier that fixes retroactively the meaning of a chain of signifiers, so that every earlier choice comes to mean otherwise.

Comparison with other games clarifies what is distinctive here. *BioShock* (2K Boston and 2K Australia, 2007) reveals that its protagonist has been obeying a conditioned trigger phrase all along, so that the player's apparent choices were compliance; *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (Konami, 2001) reveals that its protagonist's mission was an engineered simulation staged by a hidden authority to shape him. Both twists indict the player's obedience. *KOTOR*'s twist indicts the player's authorship. The player is not the one who was programmed but, through character creation and the save file, the one who did the programming.

6.7 *Save and Load: Amnesty and the Ring of Gyges*

The save file permits the player to commit an act, observe its consequences and reload. It is the player's amnesty—a forgetting without truth—and the ring of Gyges of §3.4. The player's power over the protagonist's past mirrors the Council's over Revan's. Against it stands Nietzsche's thought of eternal recurrence, posed as a demon's question: if this life, exactly as lived, had to be lived again innumerable times, would you curse the demon or bless him (*The Gay Science* §341)? Eternal recurrence is the anti-save, a test of whether one can affirm one's acts without revision. Players who bind themselves never to reload after a choice practice what Jon Elster analyzed as precommitment, the binding of oneself in advance to protect future choice from present weakness (*Ulysses and the Sirens*, 1979). The ascetic player restores to choice the gravity the save file abolishes.

Replay occupies the position of Er (§3.7). The player who has not drunk from Lethe watches a new protagonist choose with knowledge the protagonist lacks, and on a second passage every clue—Bastila's evasions, the Council's

murmurs, the protagonist's preternatural progress—becomes legible. The text is unchanged and, as in Borges's Menard, it is a different text.

6.8 *Mask and Persona*

Revan's mask, glimpsed in flashback, is the game's most enduring icon. The Latin *persona* first meant the mask of the theatrical actor—the ancient etymology from *per-sonare*, "to sound through," is doubtful—and from it derives the concept of the person, which Boethius defined as an individual substance of a rational nature (*Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* III). Jung named *persona* the mask of the collective psyche, a compromise between individual and society concerning what one should appear to be, and *shadow* the unacknowledged side of the personality; individuation requires integrating the shadow without being possessed by it (*Two Essays on Analytical Psychology*; *Aion*, 1951).

The protagonist's fabricated identity is a persona imposed from without; Revan is its shadow. The reveal does not remove a mask to disclose a face. It removes one mask to disclose another—Revan's own. Beneath personae lie further personae: the self as a palimpsest of masks. Jungian individuation corresponds to the light path, which assumes Revan's name without Revan's will; possession by the shadow corresponds to the dark ending, in which the persona is discarded and the shadow takes the throne.

6.9 *Conclusion: The Third Mnemonic Regime*

Beside the Jedi's forgetting and the Sith's grievance, the alignment system constitutes a third mnemonic regime: an archive that remembers what the subject forgets, every flagged act tallied. Bernard Stiegler's concept of tertiary retention—memory exteriorized in technical supports (*Technics and Time*, 1994–2001)—describes it precisely. The meter is the protagonist's moral memory held in the machine. Through character creation and the save file, meanwhile, the player occupies the Council's seat as author of the false identity and administrator of its forgetting. The procedural ethics of *KOTOR* thus holds a mirror to its political theology: the player does to the protagonist what the Council did to Revan.



Part Four

Dialectics

Chapter

VII

Masters, Apprentices, and Machines: The Dialectics of the Sith

7.1 Korriban: The Academy beside the Graves

7.2 Hegel: Lordship, Bondage, and the Apprentice

7.3 Girard: The Mimetic Triangle and the Scapegoat

7.4 Milton, Prometheus, and the Devil's Party

7.5 The Rule of Two as Retrospective Theory

7.6 The Star Forge and the Infinite Empire

7.7 Technology, Freedom, and the Destruction of the Forge

7.8 Conclusion

7.1 *Korriban: The Academy beside the Graves*

Korriban, the ancient Sith homeworld, houses two institutions: the academy at Dreshdae, directed by Master Uthar Wynn and his Twi'lek apprentice Yuthura Ban, and the Valley of the Dark Lords, whose tombs—of Naga Sadow, Ajunta Pall, Tulak Hord, Marka Ragnos—hold the remains of Sith antiquity. The protagonist infiltrates the academy to reach the Star Map sealed in Naga Sadow's tomb. Students compete for "prestige," the academy's currency of advancement; only the most prestigious will be admitted to the Sith, and the competition licenses sabotage, deception and murder. Catechetical exchanges examine the protagonist on the meaning of the Sith Code. The Valley is a necropolis that functions as an archive: the Sith remember their dead lords, and some of the dead, lingering as spirits, still remember themselves. Where the Jedi forbid mourning, the Sith build their school beside the graves. The mnemocracy has its capital in a cemetery.

Foucault described disciplinary power as operating through hierarchical observation, normalizing judgment and the examination, which combines surveillance with normalization and makes each individual a "case" (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975). Korriban perverts discipline. Its examinations rank students by their capacity to violate norms; its normalizing judgment norms transgression itself. The prestige economy is a ledger in the sense of §6.4—a Sith alignment meter that measures cruelty as the Republic's measures virtue—so that the protagonist's progress through Korriban doubles the player's progress through the game, points accruing for acts that an institution has flagged. Yuthura Ban, a former slave, embodies the pedagogy of ressentiment: she came to the Sith in order never again to be powerless, and she plots against Uthar and solicits the protagonist's help. The protagonist may kill her or persuade her to seek the Jedi. Her possible conversion shows that the memory of chains need not issue in domination; a remembered injury can become the ground of solidarity.

7.2 *Hegel: Lordship, Bondage, and the Apprentice*

In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) Hegel holds that self-consciousness exists only in being recognized by another self-consciousness, and that the meeting of two such consciousnesses issues in a struggle to the death, since each must prove its freedom by risking life (§§178–187). The one who prefers life to recognition becomes the bondsman; the one who risks death becomes the lord. But the lord's victory is hollow, for he is recognized by a consciousness he regards as a thing, and such recognition is worthless. The bondsman, through his fear of death—"the absolute Lord"—and through formative labor upon the world, at-

tains a self-consciousness the lord cannot reach (§§188–196). Alexandre Kojève made this dialectic the motor of history and the master an existential impasse whose future belongs to the slave (*Introduction to the Reading of Hegel*, 1947).

The Sith relation of master and apprentice institutionalizes the struggle while forbidding its resolution. The apprentice's recognition is worthless while the apprentice is weak and lethal once the apprentice is strong enough for the recognition to mean something. Recognition and betrayal coincide: the apprentice becomes worthy of the master at the moment he can kill him. Hence the structural betrayals of the game—Malak against Revan, Yuthura against Uthar, the turned Bastila installed as Malak's apprentice and therefore as his eventual rival. The Sith are a society of masters condemned to repeat the struggle in every generation, and in Hegelian terms they never reach the labor through which the bondsman becomes free: they do not work, they take, and the Star Forge that works for them (§7.6) confirms their incapacity. The resolution Hegel announces at the threshold of the dialectic—an "I that is We and We that is I" (§177)—is what the light-side protagonist achieves with the companions, and what the redemption of Bastila enacts: recognition offered as a gift to one who betrayed, rather than staked as a wager in a struggle.

7.3 *Girard: The Mimetic Triangle and the Scapegoat*

René Girard argued that desire is triangular: a subject desires an object because a model desires it, and when the model inhabits the subject's own world this internal mediation breeds envy and rivalry, until desire becomes metaphysical—a desire for the model's very being (*Deceit, Desire and the Novel*, 1961). Mimetic rivalry escalates into a sacrificial crisis in which differences dissolve and antagonists become "monstrous doubles"; order is restored by the unanimous violence of all against a surrogate victim whose expulsion founds the sacred (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *The Scapegoat*, 1982).

The game's central triangle is Revan, Malak and Bastila. Malak desires Bastila not for herself but because she is bound to Revan—by the rescue, by the bond, by Revan's prior claim as master. His desire is metaphysical, a desire to occupy Revan's being, and each of his acts imitates Revan in order to replace him: the betrayal of Revan's flagship, the turning of Bastila, the pursuit of the Star Forge that Revan found. The model is the obstacle; Malak cannot become Revan without destroying him, and cannot destroy him without becoming his imitation. Jedi and Sith, locked in reciprocal violence across millennia, are monstrous doubles of the same kind: both manipulate minds, both instrumentalize persons, both seek the Star Forge—the Council through the protagonist, Malak through his fleets.

Revan serves as the scapegoat of both orders. The Republic projects its war guilt onto its fallen hero; Malak's empire measures its failures against Revan's absence; the Council expels Revan from his own person in order to purify its instrument. Derrida noted that the *pharmakon* is kin to the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled from the city in times of crisis ("Plato's Pharmacy," 1968). The Council's *pharmakon*—its cure by identity—required a *pharmakos*, Revan expelled from himself. The light ending breaks the sacrificial logic, because the scapegoat returns and is not expelled again. It takes responsibility, which no scapegoat does.

7.4 *Milton, Prometheus, and the Devil's Party*

Milton's Satan declares that "The mind is its own place, and in itself / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" and that it is "Better to reign in Hell, than serve in Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.254–255, 263). Blake replied that Milton wrote in fetters of angels and God and at liberty of devils and hell because he was a true poet and of the Devil's party without knowing it (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, c. 1790–1793). The dark-side ending of *KOTOR* enacts a Satanic coronation: Revan enthroned with Bastila beside him and the Sith host acclaiming, Pandaemonium raised anew (cf. *Paradise Lost* II.1–10). The seduction of the dark path—its rhetoric of self-determination and contempt for servitude—is Satanic rhetoric, and its attraction for players renews Blake's observation, with the difference that players are of the Devil's party and know it.

Shelley's preface to *Prometheus Unbound* (1820) concedes that Satan is the only imaginary being resembling Prometheus but judges Prometheus the more poetical character, being exempt from the taints of ambition, envy, revenge and the desire for personal aggrandizement that mar the hero of *Paradise Lost*. Here lies the decisive difference between the Sith and the light-side Revan. The Sith Code's chains, and the Star Forge the Sith seize as Prometheus seized fire from Hephaestus' forge, are Promethean in imagery and Satanic in motive.

Shelley's drama also shows how Prometheus is unbound, and the mechanism is the anamnetic mechanism of *KOTOR*'s light path. At the opening, Prometheus, chained for ages, has forgotten the words of the curse he once hurled at Jupiter. He asks to hear it; the Earth summons the Phantasm of Jupiter to repeat it; and having heard his own malediction spoken by another, Prometheus repents: "It doth repent me: words are quick and vain; / Grief for awhile is blind, and so was mine. / I wish no living thing to suffer pain" (Act I). The retraction begins the liberation. Jupiter falls not to Prometheus' violence but to Demogorgon, and Prometheus is freed without becoming a tyrant in turn. The hero must recover a forgotten curse in order to revoke it. Forgetting

will not serve, since the unremembered curse still binds; remembering in order to repeat will not serve, since reaffirming the curse would make Prometheus a new Jupiter. What frees him is remembering in order to revoke. The protagonist of *KOTOR* hears Revan's deeds narrated by others—Malak, Bastila, Carth, the Council—and revokes them by choosing otherwise. Shelley supplies the Romantic counter-myth to the Sith Code: the chains break when hatred is retracted, not when power is seized.

Two further figures complete the Sith's temptations. Goethe's Mephistopheles presents himself as part of that power which eternally wills evil and eternally works good (*Faust* I, 1335–1336), the formula of every theodicy of necessary evil, which the sequel would extend to Revan (Chapter VIII). Dostoevsky's Raskolnikov argues in his article on crime that humanity divides into the ordinary and the extraordinary, the latter entitled to step over blood for an idea (*Crime and Punishment*, Part III, ch. 5), the formula of the exceptional individual's self-license. Raskolnikov's redemption through confession and Sonya's love prefigures the redemption of Bastila, with the roles reversed: in *KOTOR* the redeemer is the former extraordinary man.

7.5 *The Rule of Two as Retrospective Theory*

Karpyshyn's *Darth Bane* trilogy (2006–2009) narrates a Sith reformation set a millennium before the films. Bane, a former miner trained at the Korriban academy, repudiates the many-headed Brotherhood of Darkness, engineers its destruction, and institutes the Rule of Two: one master to embody power and one apprentice to crave it, the apprentice succeeding by overthrowing the master. The trilogy reads as its author's theory of what *KOTOR* dramatized. The Sith multiplicity—Malak's empire, Korriban's academy of mutual murder—is self-consuming; Hegel's struggle among many masters is mere chaos. Bane domesticates the struggle into dynastic succession, so that betrayal ceases to be a failure of the order and becomes its procedure of reproduction. The problem of recognition is solved by making the apprentice's eventual murder of the master the form recognition takes. The mnemocracy perfects itself as a lineage—a chain, once again—of masters each remembered by the one who killed him.

7.6 *The Star Forge and the Infinite Empire*

The Star Forge is a Rakatan station of immense antiquity orbiting a star in the Lehon system. It draws on the star's energy and on the dark side to manufacture warships, droids and matériel without end, and it amplifies and corrupts those who command it. The Rakata built their Infinite Empire by enslaving

other species through Force-based technology; when they lost their connection to the Force, the game recounts, the empire collapsed, its slaves rebelled, and the Rakata degenerated into warring tribes on their homeworld.

Heidegger located the essence of modern technology in *Gestell*, enframing, a mode of revealing that challenges nature to yield energy that can be extracted and stored, so that everything appears as standing-reserve (*Bestand*); the hydroelectric plant on the Rhine turns the river into a supplier of water power, while Hölderlin's hymn names another Rhine ("The Question Concerning Technology," 1954). The Star Forge is *Gestell* in its purest fictional form: a star enframed as standing-reserve, its fire converted into an inexhaustible supply of instruments of war. Marx wrote that capital is dead labor which, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labor (*Capital*, vol. I, 1867, ch. 10). The Star Forge is dead labor perfected, an engine that produces without workers and feeds instead on the Force and on the wills of its masters, corrupting them as capital corrupts its personifications. The Rakata, who once enslaved whole species for their labor, built a machine that made slaves unnecessary and enslaved its builders.

The game's precursor sublime has a lineage. Lovecraft's Elder Things bred the shoggoths as servants and were overthrown by them (*At the Mountains of Madness*, 1936); Arthur C. Clarke's monolith is a precursor technology that uplifts and destabilizes (*2001: A Space Odyssey*, 1968); Oswald Spengler described civilizations hardening into technics before their death (*The Decline of the West*, 1918–1922). The Infinite Empire is Spenglerian civilization in its terminal phase: domination by technique, exhausted.

The Rakatan schism reproduces the mnemopolitical triad in miniature. The tribe led by the One seeks to reclaim the Temple and the old dominion: remembrance as restoration, a mnemocracy. The Elders preserve the memory of the Infinite Empire in order to repudiate it: remembrance as penitence, the anamnetic position. The degenerate remainder lives in amnesia. The protagonist—Revan's revenant on ground Revan once trod—must choose among them, and the light path sides with the Elders, who remember in order not to repeat. That the game reproduces its binary on a planet of beings severed from the Force is strong evidence that its true axis was always memory rather than the Force.

7.7 *Technology, Freedom, and the Destruction of the Forge*

The Star Forge's corruption of its users—it deepens Bastila's fall and feeds Malak's strength—introduces a technological determinism into the fiction: the machine shapes the will. Heidegger, citing Hölderlin's "Patmos"—"Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch" (but where danger is, the saving power also grows)—held that the danger of *Gestell* harbors a turning, and in his posthu-

mously published interview with *Der Spiegel* (conducted 1966, published 1976) he said that only a god can save us. *KOTOR* offers a humbler saving power: refusal. The light path ends with the Forge's destruction, an act that does not seize the apparatus for better ends—the temptation the Council and the Republic would have faced had they captured it—but annihilates it. In Benjamin's terms (§4.6), this approaches divine violence: law-destroying rather than law-founding, directed at the apparatus of mythic domination itself rather than at founding a new order upon it. The dark path takes the Forge, and the new Dark Lord becomes its personification, as Marx's capitalist is capital personified.

7.8 *Conclusion*

The Sith dialectic is a dialectic without synthesis: masters who cannot recognize one another, mimetic rivals collapsing into doubles, a Promethean rhetoric animated by Satanic motives, a lineage of betrayal, and an apparatus that converts a star into standing-reserve and its masters into instruments. The mnemocracy remembers everything except how to stop. Its alternatives are glimpsed in Shelley's Prometheus, in the Rakatan Elders and in the redemption of Bastila. Chapter VIII turns to the voices within the game that unsettle the binary from outside the Force.

Chapter

VIII

Heterodoxies of Balance: Jolee Bindo, Canderous Ordo, HK-47, and the Critique of the Binary

8.1 Jolee Bindo: The Sage outside the Temple

8.2 Canderous Ordo: The Ethics of the Worthy Enemy

8.3 HK-47: The Austinian Droid

8.4 Mission and Zaalbar: Bonds outside the Codes

8.5 Balance against the Binary.

8.6 Kreia, Herbert, and the Critique of Saviors

8.7 BioWare after the Line

8.8 Conclusion

8.1 *Jolee Bindo: The Sage outside the Temple*

Jolee Bindo is an aged Jedi living in self-imposed exile in the Shadowlands of Kashyyyk, who has left the Order's discipline without abandoning the good and who speaks of a beloved wife lost to the dark side. His characteristic teaching distinguishes love from the possessive passions the Order conflates with it—jealousy, obsession, the clutching that fears loss—and mocks the Council's habit of mistaking rigidity for wisdom. Players often call him a "gray" Jedi, but his position is not a midpoint on the meter. He is kind, committed and good; what he refuses is dogma. Gray, in his case, names epistemic humility rather than moral compromise.

His philosophical lineage is plural. Zhuangzi's sage praises the useless tree that survives because carpenters disdain it (*Zhuangzi*, chs. 1 and 4), learns from Cook Ding, who carves an ox by following its natural seams (ch. 3), and doubts, after dreaming he was a butterfly, which was the dreamer (ch. 2). Against him stands Confucius' doctrine of the rectification of names: if names are not correct, speech does not accord with reality and affairs cannot succeed (*Analects* 13.3). The Council practices rectification of names in the most literal manner, assigning the protagonist a name and a role; Jolee practices Zhuangzi's playful unnaming. Diogenes of Sinope, who lived in a storage jar and told Alexander to stand out of his sunlight (Diogenes Laertius, *Lives* VI), is another ancestor: Jolee's hut is a *pithos*, and his sarcasm toward the Council is Cynic *parrhēsia*, the frank speech that Foucault's final lectures identified as the Cynics' distinctive practice of truth-telling at personal risk (*The Courage of Truth*, lectures of 1984). Montaigne's skeptical motto, *Que sais-je?* (*Essais* II.12), names his register, and Hesse's *Siddhartha* (1922), whose hero honors the Buddha yet learns at last from a river and a ferryman, names his pedagogy: wisdom cannot be transmitted as doctrine.

Jolee's distinction between love and possession is, moreover, Spinozist. Spinoza defines love as joy accompanied by the idea of an external cause (*Ethics* III, Definitions of the Affects 6) and jealousy as a vacillation compounded of love, hatred and envy (III, P35, Scholium). The problem is not affect but passivity; an understood love becomes an action. Jolee arrives by experience where Spinoza arrives by geometry, and both stand against the Jedi Code's annihilation of emotion and the Sith Code's enslavement to passion.

Le Guin's fable "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) offers a further frame. A city's happiness depends on the misery of one child kept in a cellar; every citizen is shown the child, most accept the bargain, and a few walk away. The Republic's safety in *KOTOR* rests on a hidden cost of the same structure, and the reveal tells the protagonist that they are it: the self erased so

that the Republic might live. Jolee left the Order over its rigidity rather than over a hidden victim, but his departure has the form of Le Guin's walkers, and the protagonist's discovery supplies the cellar he never saw. The light path declines both of the fable's options. It neither accepts the bargain nor walks away; it opens the cellar and asks the Republic to answer for what it held there.

8.2 *Canderous Ordo: The Ethics of the Worthy Enemy*

Chapter II read the Mandalorian ethic as a master morality without metaphysics. Carl Schmitt's *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) sharpens that reading. Schmitt distinguished the conventional enemy, the real enemy and the absolute enemy, and credited classical European public law with "bracketing" war by treating the adversary as a *justus hostis*, a legitimate opponent rather than a criminal; ideological war, by contrast, produces absolute enmity, in which the enemy must be annihilated. The Mandalorians fight the *justus hostis* and honor Revan as a worthy opponent. The Jedi–Sith war is a war of absolute enmity, each side metaphysically evil to the other. The Force binary criminalizes the enemy; the Force-blind Mandalorians bracket war.

Hence Canderous's indifference to the reveal. For him identity is performance in combat, and Revan's metaphysical alignment is irrelevant to Revan's excellence. Francis Fukuyama revived Plato's *thumos* and distinguished *isothymia*, the desire to be recognized as equal, from *megalothymia*, the desire to be recognized as superior (*The End of History and the Last Man*, 1992). The Mandalorian crusade was megalothymic, a Kojèvean struggle for recognition through combat, and Revan's victory both defeated and satisfied it: the Mandalorians found a master worth losing to. Their memory of defeat is commemorative, without grievance—the monumental history of §2.4.

Schmitt's distinction must be applied with the correction made in §2.4. The crusaders who honored worthy opponents also assaulted Cathar, whose survivors fled as refugees. Schmitt's own history of bracketed war confined it to a circle of mutually recognized enemies and suspended it beyond the lines that bounded that circle (*Der Nomos der Erde*, 1950). The Mandalorian ethic reproduces that boundary: Canderous's honor is genuine within the circle and silent about what lies outside it.

8.3 *HK-47: The Austinian Droid*

HK-47, the assassin droid purchased on Tatooine under the guise of a translator, and built—as his recovering memory discloses—by Revan, calls organic beings "meatbags" and prefixes nearly every utterance with a label naming its

function: Statement, Query, Observation, Commentary, Answer. J. L. Austin distinguished the locutionary act of saying something meaningful, the illocutionary act performed in saying it—asserting, asking, warning, promising—and the perlocutionary act of producing effects by saying it; the explicit performative makes illocutionary force explicit (*How to Do Things with Words*, 1962). HK-47 is an Austinian machine that renders his illocutionary force explicit at every turn, a parody of perfect communicative transparency.

The parody carries a philosophical charge. The Jedi mind trick disguises perlocutionary manipulation as ordinary locution; HK announces exactly what he is doing. The assassin is, in this narrow sense, more respectful of rational agency than the Jedi persuader, because he lets his interlocutor know when he is being threatened. The joke is that the most honest speaker in the game is a murderer. HK's misanthropy belongs to the tradition of Swift's fourth voyage in *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), where rational horses rule and bestial Yahoos are human; "meatbag" Yahoo-izes organics from the machine's vantage and satirizes the species that built him. He inverts Asimov's laws of robotics (*I, Robot*, 1950), being made to kill, and revises Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), being an instrument that does not rebel. His loyalty runs not to humanity but to his maker, across amnesia and indifferent to alignment. He is the only companion delighted by the reveal, because he wants his master back—the mnemocratic joy of a memory restored.

8.4 *Mission and Zaalbar: Bonds outside the Codes*

Mission Vao, a Twi'lek adolescent of the Taris Undercity abandoned by her brother Griff, and Zaalbar, a Wookiee exiled from Kashyyyk for using his claws—a grave taboo—against his brother Chuundar, who was trafficking with slavers, are bound by life-debts and by friendship. Their ethic is neither Jedi nor Sith but an ethic of particular bonds. Carol Gilligan identified an ethic of care attentive to relationships and responsibilities against a justice-centered model of moral development (*In a Different Voice*, 1982), and Nel Noddings grounded ethics in the caring relation itself (*Caring*, 1984). Mission and Zaalbar speak this different voice, which neither Code can hear: the Jedi forbid attachment and the Sith instrumentalize it.

The game's romances belong to the same different voice. Carth for a female protagonist, Bastila for a male one, and Juhani—widely cited as the first lesbian character in Star Wars media—for a female protagonist are attachments of exactly the kind the Jedi Code forbids. *KOTOR* treats romance as a vehicle of fidelity rather than corruption: where the romance with Bastila has been pursued, her redemption on the Star Forge is staged as an act of love (§9.9). The game's structure thus contradicts the Order's doctrine of attachment.

Josiah Royce defined loyalty as the willing and thoroughgoing devotion of a person to a cause and commended, as its highest form, a "loyalty to loyalty" that respects the loyalties of others (*The Philosophy of Loyalty*, 1908). The Wookiee life-debt is such a loyalty, but its cause is ambiguous. The dark path's culminating test, in which the protagonist may invoke Zaalbar's life-debt to order him to kill Mission, poses the ambiguity as a demand: loyalty to a master against loyalty to the good and to a friend. Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) defends Abraham's willingness to sacrifice Isaac as a teleological suspension of the ethical, intelligible only if the command comes from God. The Dark Lord demands of Zaalbar an Abrahamic sacrifice without God—a suspension of the ethical for nothing higher than a master's will. The test exposes the Sith ethic as a parody of faith: obedience as such, without a *telos*.

8.5 *Balance against the Binary*

The Daoist alternative to Manichaean exclusion is stated in the second chapter of the *Daodejing*: when all the world knows beauty as beauty, ugliness arises; being and non-being produce each other, difficult and easy complete each other, long and short shape each other. Opposites are mutually generative rather than mutually exclusive, and the figure of *yin* and *yang* contains each within the other. Ursula K. Le Guin, who translated the *Daodejing* (1997), built the magic of Earthsea on an Equilibrium that every act of power disturbs, so that the wise mage acts only from need (*A Wizard of Earthsea*, 1968). Moorcock's Cosmic Balance (§2.5) performs the same office in sword-and-sorcery. Hermann Hesse's *Steppenwolf* (1927) contains a "Treatise" diagnosing its hero's self-image as man-and-wolf as a convenient fiction: he is not two but a multitude of selves. The binary of light and dark is the Steppenwolf's error raised to cosmology.

Le Guin also supplies the most precise rebuttal of a single line of the Jedi Code. In *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) the Handdara of Gethen cultivate ignorance as a discipline: their Foretellers can answer questions about the future, yet their teacher holds that what makes life possible is the permanent uncertainty of not knowing what comes next. Where the Code declares that there is no ignorance, only knowledge, the Handdara treat unknowing as the ground of freedom. The protagonist's ignorance of their own past, administered by the Council, is the dark mirror of the Handdara's chosen unknowing: the one imposed, the other embraced.

Borges gave the critique its most elegant form. In "The Theologians" (1949) the orthodox Aurelian brings about the burning of the heretic John of Pannonia; after his own death Aurelian learns that for the unfathomable divinity he and John—accuser and victim, orthodox and heretic—formed a single person. Jedi

and Sith, on this reading, are one person in the eyes of the Force: a reading the game's scalar monism already encodes (§6.3), and that Revan, who has been both, embodies.

8.6 *Kreia, Herbert, and the Critique of Saviors*

Knights of the Old Republic II: The Sith Lords (Obsidian, 2004), led in design and writing by Chris Avellone, is the first game's philosophical commentary. Its mentor, Kreia—revealed as Darth Traya and as one of Revan's former teachers—rejects both Codes and the Force itself as a power that binds the living to its will. She teaches that apparent kindness can harm, rebuking in a scene on Nar Shaddaa the protagonist's charity to a beggar by tracing its consequences, and she interprets Revan's fall as purposive, a descent undertaken to prepare the Republic for a greater threat beyond the known galaxy. The sequel thus completes the Weberian reading of §4.9 and adds a Mephistophelean theodicy: Revan willed evil and worked good, or willed good through evil.

Kreia's apologia also has a Hegelian form. Hegel held that world history advances through the passions of individuals who pursue their own ends while reason works through them toward ends they do not intend—the cunning of reason (*Lectures on the Philosophy of History*, 1837). On Kreia's account Revan is a world-historical individual in this sense: a passion that history spent for purposes beyond it.

Frank Herbert's Dune cycle supplies the template for both the Council and Kreia's apologia. The Bene Gesserit manipulate bloodlines across generations to produce the Kwisatz Haderach and, through their Missionaria Protectiva, sow protective myths among peoples so that their members may later exploit them (*Dune*, 1965). The Council's engineering of the protagonist—identity fabricated, bond arranged, destiny steered—is Bene Gesserit statecraft. Paul Atreides, the engineered messiah, unleashes a galactic jihad, and Herbert described the saga as a warning against charismatic leaders ("Dune Genesis," 1980). Revan, the charismatic hero of the Mandalorian Wars who became a conqueror, is Herbert's warning in Star Wars dress. Leto II's Golden Path, a tyranny of millennia imposed so that humanity might survive (*God Emperor of Dune*, 1981), is the template for Kreia's Revan: a tyranny justified by a necessity only the tyrant can see. The first *KOTOR* does not endorse such a theodicy. It leaves the motive of Revan's fall opaque, and the opacity is a virtue: it refuses to let the protagonist's past be redeemed by a hidden necessity, so that redemption must be achieved forward.

8.7 *BioWare after the Line*

BioWare's subsequent design history reads as a sustained revision of *KOTOR*'s single axis. *Jade Empire* (2005) replaced light and dark with the Way of the Open Palm and the Way of the Closed Fist, presented as rival accounts of harmony—selfless care for others against the strength won through self-reliance and struggle—each claiming its own benevolence, though the system remained a line. *Mass Effect* (2007), for which Karpyshyn was lead writer, split the meter into independent Paragon and Renegade tallies, so that a character could accrue both: in effect a return from the line to the plane of Gygax's two axes. *Dragon Age: Origins* (2009) largely devolved moral evaluation into the approval and disapproval of individual companions, distributing morality across relationships rather than summing it on a gauge; Obsidian's *KOTOR II* had already introduced an influence system by which companions shifted in response to the protagonist.

The trajectory runs from a Platonic ledger, in which the soul is weighed on a single scale, toward a Humean sentimentalism, in which moral distinctions arise from the approbation and disapprobation of persons through sympathy (Hume, *Treatise* III, 1739–1740; *Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals*, 1751), and toward P. F. Strawson's reactive attitudes (§9.9). *KOTOR*'s own companions—Carth's trust and resentment, Canderous's respect, Mission's affection—already point in that direction.

8.8 *Conclusion*

The heterodox voices—Jolee's sage humility, Canderous's agonal honor, HK-47's mechanical candor, the care and loyalty of Mission and Zaalbar, the Daoist and literary critiques of opposition, Kreia's anti-theology—converge on one point. The binary is an artifact of two institutions' claims to own the Force, and life outside those claims has other measures. These voices do not supply a third Code; they supply practices. Chapter IX shows that those practices are concentrated in the part of the game criticism most often dismisses: the side-quests.



Part Five

Ethics and Afterlives

Chapter

IX

The Ethics of Attention: Peripheral Suffering and the Anamnetic Third

9.1 Against the Meter: Attention

9.2 Taris: The Vertical City and the Erased Promised Land

9.3 Dantooine: Feud and Fall

9.4 Tatooine: Frontier and Recognition

9.5 Kashyyyk: Comprador and Liberation

9.6 Manaan: Neutrality, Kolto, and the Progenitor

9.7 Korriban: The Father Who Rescues the Son

9.8 Memoria Passionis and the Anamnetic Third

9.9 Forgiveness and Promise

9.10 Anamnetic Fidelity and Anamnetic Republicanism

9.11 Conclusion

9.1 *Against the Meter: Attention*

Criticism of *KOTOR*'s morality—including this dissertation's own critique of the meter in Chapter VI—tends to locate the game's ethics in its binary gauge and its final choice. This chapter argues that the game's ethical substance lies elsewhere: in the side-quests that occupy most of its hours, each of which stages a particular suffering at the margins of the galactic war. These episodes are commonly treated as filler between the Star Maps. They are better understood as exercises of attention.

Iris Murdoch, borrowing the term from Simone Weil, held that what distinguishes the active moral agent is attention, a patient regard, both just and loving, fixed on a particular reality outside the self, and that moral life consists less in discrete choices than in the continuous work of seeing (*The Sovereignty of Good*, 1970). Her example is a mother-in-law who finds her son's wife vulgar and juvenile and who, without any outward act, by attending justly, comes to see her as refreshingly simple and spontaneous: a moral change no external tally could register. Weil called attention the rarest and purest form of generosity (letter to Joë Bousquet, 1942) and wrote that the capacity to give one's attention to a sufferer is so rare and difficult as to be almost a miracle ("Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God," 1942). At their best, the side-quests of *KOTOR* are a curriculum in that capacity. They ask the player to stop, listen and see a particular person or people whom the war's grand narrative does not see.

9.2 *Taris: The Vertical City and the Erased Promised Land*

Taris is stratified vertically: the gleaming Upper City, the gang-ruled Lower City, the Undercity of exiles beneath it, and below that the sewers. The arrangement inherits Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), whose workers toil beneath the city of the privileged, and H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895), whose Eloi live above the subterranean Morlocks. The Upper City's casual xenophobia, exemplified in Sith troopers' harassment of alien residents that the protagonist may halt or abet, marks the first stratum of exclusion. The Undercity marks the second. Its inhabitants are outcasts expelled from above, and its fringes are haunted by rakghouls, victims of a plague that turns its sufferers into monsters. Julia Kristeva's account of the abject, what a social body expels in order to constitute itself and which returns as horror (*Powers of Horror*, 1980), and Foucault's account of biopolitical power as the power to "make live and let die" (*Society Must Be Defended*, lectures of 1976) describe the Undercity precisely: a population let die, its abjection literalized as monstrosity.

Within this zone the game places one of its quietest quests. An old outcast, Rukil, keeps faith with the legend of a Promised Land, a refuge beyond the Undercity that his lost apprentices sought; the protagonist may recover their journals and confirm the path. The quest rewrites the Exodus narrative from below: a people's hope preserved in a prophet's memory and in fragmentary writings—hypomnemata again (§3.3). Moses dies on Mount Nebo having seen a land he will not enter (Deut. 34). Taris offers a crueler variant. The Promised Land is located and confirmed, and soon afterward the planet is annihilated by Malak's fleet. The bombardment erases not only a world but its unfulfilled hopes, and the only witnesses who survive are the protagonist's party. Mission, a child of the Undercity, carries its memory aboard the *Ebon Hawk*. The game's first and most consequential archive is therefore human: the survivors who remember the Undercity's hope after its obliteration.

The ethics of that witness can be stated more exactly. Primo Levi argued that the survivors of the Nazi camps were not the true witnesses: those who saw the worst did not return, or returned unable to speak, and the survivors speak by proxy for them (*The Drowned and the Saved*, 1986). Giorgio Agamben made this lacuna the structure of testimony as such (*Remnants of Auschwitz*, 1998). No equivalence between a fictional planetary bombardment and a historical genocide is implied; the borrowing is structural. The party leaves Taris carrying a testimony whose true witnesses are dead, and Mission, the only one of them who belonged to the Undercity, must speak for those who did not escape. Answerability toward the dead—the second component of anamnetic fidelity (§9.10)—begins here.

9.3 *Dantooine: Feud and Fall*

On Dantooine the Sandral and Matale families wage a feud in the shadow of the Jedi Enclave, while the son of one house and the daughter of the other love each other. The structure is that of *Romeo and Juliet* (c. 1595), and the protagonist occupies the place of Friar Laurence, the cleric-mediator whose plan failed in Verona. *KOTOR* allows the protagonist to succeed where Laurence failed—reconciling the houses through evidence, persuasion and patient mediation—or to let the feud consume them. The Jedi of the Enclave, a short walk away, have not intervened. The quest is a miniature critique of Jedi detachment: peace achieved not through the Order's serene distance but through an apprentice's close attention to a particular quarrel.

Dantooine also hosts Juhani's grove (§5.9), where a fallen apprentice's guilt rests on a false memory and her redemption depends on a truth told gently. The Enclave itself is later destroyed by Malak's fleet, and its ruins, shown in the

sequel, complete the irony: the Order's detachment from Dantooine's quarrels did not protect it from the war it had refused to enter.

9.4 *Tatooine: Frontier and Recognition*

On Tatooine the Czerka Corporation's mining operations encroach upon the lands of the Sand People, and Czerka offers bounties for their deaths. The protagonist may hunt them, or may enter their encampment and broker terms between the nomads and the corporation—a peace mediated, in the game's dark irony, through the translation circuits of an assassin droid. The scenario inherits the settler-colonial imaginary of the American Western, in which the Indigenous nomad appears as a menace beyond the frontier (John Ford's *The Searchers*, 1956, is its canonical and self-troubled instance), and the orientalizing representation of desert peoples that Edward Said anatomized (*Orientalism*, 1978).

KOTOR does not escape these inheritances; it permits genocidal choices and pays for them in dark-side standing and credits. But its light path enacts what Axel Honneth called the struggle for recognition, in which social conflict is driven by the demand to be acknowledged as a person and a participant (*The Struggle for Recognition*, 1992), and what Charles Taylor called the politics of recognition, in which misrecognition inflicts a real harm (1992). To learn to speak with the Sand People is to recognize them; the treaty is recognition institutionalized, however fragile.

9.5 *Kashyyyk: Comprador and Liberation*

On Kashyyyk the protagonist finds Czerka trading in Wookiee slaves under the protection of Chuundar, who usurped the chieftaincy of his father Freyyr by colluding with the corporation and who exiled Zaalbar when Zaalbar attacked him with his claws. The protagonist may side with the usurper and the corporation or restore Freyyr and free the enslaved. Chapter IV read Chuundar through Fanon's comprador; the episode also stages a conflict between moral cultures. Ruth Benedict's distinction between shame cultures, governed by external sanctions of honor, and guilt cultures, governed by internalized conscience (*The Chrysanthemum and the Sword*, 1946), and E. R. Dodds's application of the distinction to archaic Greece (*The Greeks and the Irrational*, 1951), illuminate Zaalbar's exile. His use of claws is a transgression against honor, and his redemption requires public restoration before his people, not private absolution. The game respects that difference: the protagonist cannot forgive Zaalbar on the Wookiees' behalf, and only the community can readmit him. Attention here means attending to a moral grammar not one's own.

9.6 *Manaan: Neutrality, Kolto, and the Progenitor*

Manaan, the ocean world of the Selkath, supplies kolto, a healing substance on which both Republic and Sith depend, and enforces strict neutrality: violence in Ahto City is punished under Selkath law, and both powers keep embassies there. Kant argued that the spirit of commerce, which cannot coexist with war, would in time compel states to promote peace (*Perpetual Peace*, 1795, First Supplement). Manaan tests that hope and refutes it, since its commerce sustains the war it refuses to join: kolto heals soldiers so that they may fight again. Kolto is a *pharmakon* in Derrida's sense (§3.3), healing the wound in order to perpetuate the wounding. Neutrality on Manaan is profit from both sides of a war.

Two episodes complicate the picture. In a Selkath court the protagonist defends a Republic soldier accused of murder, assembling testimony and evidence before alien judges—an exercise in the epistemology of testimony and in justice under a law not one's own. In the depths beneath Ahto City, at a Republic harvesting station, the protagonist encounters the Progenitor, an ancient creature revered by the Selkath and able to communicate with the protagonist, whose domain extraction has disturbed. The episode stages a choice between instrumental exploitation and reverence for sacred nonhuman life. Aldo Leopold's land ethic, which measures conduct by whether it sustains or degrades the integrity, stability and beauty of the biotic community (*A Sand County Almanac*, 1949), and Arne Næss's distinction between shallow and deep ecology (1973), mark the stakes. The galactic war has an environmental periphery too, and the game asks the player to notice it.

9.7 *Korriban: The Father Who Rescues the Son*

Among Korriban's students the protagonist finds Dustil Onasi, Carth's estranged son, now a Sith acolyte who blames his absent father for Telos and has found in the academy the family he lost. The protagonist may help Carth reach him, in part by uncovering evidence that the academy murders its own students. The episode inverts the climax of *Return of the Jedi* (1983), in which the son redeems the father from the dark side: here the father, with the protagonist's help, rescues the son. Carth's paternal ethic—protective, fallible, self-reproaching—stands against both Codes, for the Jedi would not have let him have a son and the Sith took the son he had. The scene's emotional logic is anamnetic. Dustil's turn depends on remembering what the academy taught him to forget, that his father loved him, and on his father's acknowledgment of the failures Dustil remembers.

9.8 *Memoria Passionis and the Anamnetic Third*

The side-quests share a structure: each discloses a suffering that the war's grand narrative and the Republic's official memory have overlooked. Johann Baptist Metz called the memory of suffering—*memoria passionis*—a "dangerous memory" that interrupts the self-satisfied narratives of victors and grounds an anamnestic solidarity with the dead and the defeated (*Faith in History and Society*, 1977). Walter Benjamin's theses on history, written in 1940, hold that historical understanding means grasping a memory in the instant it flares up amid danger; that a victorious enemy leaves not even the dead secure; and that, as the tradition of the oppressed teaches, the state of emergency is not the exception but the rule (Theses VI and VIII). The eighth thesis completes Chapter IV's analysis of the exception. For the Wookiees in Czerka's camps, the Sand People under bounty and the abject of the Undercity, the Republic's peace has always been a state of emergency.

The three mnemonic regimes now come fully into view. The Jedi forget suffering, their own and others', by Code: lethocracy. The Sith remember only their own suffering—their chains—and inflict more: mnemocracy. The attentive protagonist remembers the suffering of others and answers it: the anamnetic third. The side-quests, so often dismissed as padding, are where the game builds this third position, one encounter at a time.

9.9 *Forgiveness and Promise*

Hannah Arendt found the remedy for the irreversibility of action in the faculty of forgiving and the remedy for its unpredictability in the faculty of promising (*The Human Condition*, 1958, §§33–34). Without forgiveness, every agent would remain bound to the consequences of a single act, unable to begin again; without promise we could not hold an identity through time. The second half of *KOTOR* is a drama of both. After the *Leviathan*, Carth—betrayed once already by his mentor Saul Karath—confronts the protagonist with the resentment of a man who has just learned that his comrade was the architect of the war that devastated his world.

P. F. Strawson's "Freedom and Resentment" (1962) grounds moral responsibility not in metaphysical freedom but in the reactive attitudes—resentment, indignation, gratitude, forgiveness—that persons adopt toward one another, and contrasts these participant attitudes with the objective attitude, in which another is regarded as a case to be managed or treated. The Council adopted the objective attitude toward Revan; Carth adopts the participant attitude. Strawson distinguishes considerations that modify reactive attitudes as excuses ("he

didn't know") from those that suspend them as exemptions, among them "he wasn't himself." In *KOTOR* that phrase is literally true, and Carth must decide whether it exempts. His eventual trust, where the player earns it, is not an exemption but a forgiveness: he continues to hold the protagonist answerable and chooses to release them from the debt.

Derrida argued that forgiveness forgives only the unforgivable: what can be forgiven by calculation is exchange, and pure forgiveness is unconditional and exceptional ("On Forgiveness," 2001). Vladimir Jankélévitch, having described forgiveness as a gratuitous gift (*Le Pardon*, 1967), later held that certain crimes are imprescriptible and that forgiveness died in the death camps (*L'Imprescriptible*, 1986). Ricoeur's epilogue to *Memory, History, Forgetting* charts a "difficult forgiveness" between these poles. *KOTOR* does not adjudicate their dispute, but it locates forgiveness where Ricoeur does: neither commanded, as by the Council's amnesty, nor extorted, as by the Sith's demand for submission, but asked for and given under conditions of truth.

Promise completes the structure. On the Star Forge the light-sided protagonist confronts the fallen Bastila and offers her return, as she once offered Revan life after Malak's betrayal. The redemption of Bastila is the protagonist's *ipse*-act in Ricoeur's sense: keeping faith with a person through change, holding a bond that both parties have betrayed. Shelley's Prometheus returns here (§7.4). The hero who recalls and revokes his own curse is freed without becoming a tyrant, and the light-side Revan frees Bastila by offering her the revocation he himself has enacted.

9.10 *Anamnetic Fidelity and Anamnetic Republicanism*

These threads can now be gathered into a definition. *Anamnetic fidelity* is answerability for a past one cannot remember, enacted before those who suffered it. It has five components:

1. *Attention*: the just and loving gaze upon particular suffering (Weil, Murdoch).
2. *Anamnestic solidarity*: remembrance of the suffering of others, not of one's own grievance alone (Metz, Benjamin).
3. *Answerability*: acceptance of second-personal address from those wronged by one's predecessor (Darwall; the fourth condition of the Reprise Criterion).
4. *Forgiveness received, not commanded*: release asked for and given under conditions of truth, as against amnesty (Arendt, Ricoeur).

5. *Promise*: *ipse*-constancy, keeping faith through change (Ricoeur), and with it the capacity to begin anew (Arendt's natality).

The political form of anamnetic fidelity is *anamnetic republicanism*. It differs from lethocracy, which secures peace by sealing the archive and amnestying the perpetrator, and from mnemocracy, which converts memory into a perpetual license for reprisal. An anamnetic republic holds its founding wrongs in custody. Its archives are open rather than sealed; its perpetrators are made answerable rather than amnestied or annihilated; its peace is founded on testimony, above all the testimony of its margins; and its unity is a promise renewed rather than a forgetting enforced. South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission, for all its acknowledged failures, approximates this form more closely than any amnesty, and Renan's nation, built on shared forgetting, is its antithesis. *KOTOR*'s light-side ending, which gathers before the Republic the survivors and witnesses of Taris, Kashyyyk, Korriban and the Star Forge, is an image of an anamnetic republic in miniature—marred by the Renanian silence that still conceals the hero's name (§4.3), and therefore incomplete.

Anamnetic fidelity is not total recall. Borges's "Funes the Memorious" (1942) imagines a man who, after a fall, remembers every perception in every detail and is thereby rendered nearly incapable of thought, because to think is to forget differences, to generalize and to abstract. A republic that remembered everything would be Funes, and the Sith come close: their grievance retains every injury and can generalize none into a principle. Nietzsche's point that the unhistorical and the historical are equally necessary (§2.4) holds here. What anamnetic fidelity requires is not an archive of everything but custody of the wrongs that bind—kept open, answerable, and capable of release through forgiveness.

9.11 *Conclusion*

The ethics of *KOTOR* is not in its meter. It is in the side-quests' discipline of attention, in the companions' reactive attitudes, in Carth's forgiveness and Bastila's redemption, and in the Rakatan Elders' memory that repudiates. Together these constitute a third position between Jedi forgetting and Sith grievance. The final chapter follows Revan beyond the game, into the forgetting the franchise itself performed.

Chapter

X

The Triple Amnesty: Canon, Player, and the Afterlives of Re-van

10.1 The First Amnesty: Diegetic

10.2 The Second Amnesty: Ludic

10.3 The Third Amnesty: Institutional

10.4 Canon and Archive

10.5 Archontic Power

10.6 Counter-Memory and the Poachers

10.7 The Three Regimes in Reception

10.8 Conclusion

10.1 *The First Amnesty: Diegetic*

The Council's refabrication of Revan is a commanded forgetting (Chapter IV), the inverse of a truth commission, exposed aboard the *Leviathan*. Within the fiction it is undone: the reveal is the return of the repressed, and the light ending a partial working-through. Two further amnesties operate beyond the frame of the fiction, and they are not undone so easily.

10.2 *The Second Amnesty: Ludic*

Chapter VI identified the player as ludic legislator, author of the false identity at character creation and administrator of forgetting through save and load. The analysis extends across playthroughs. The first passage through the game is lived under Lethe; the second is lived as Er. The replaying player knows the secret and occupies, structurally, Bastila's position—the companion who knows who the protagonist is—except that the player cannot speak and the protagonist cannot hear. The ludic amnesty is therefore double. Within a playthrough the save file erases consequences; across playthroughs the player's memory converts the new protagonist's ignorance into a dramatic irony the player administers. The irony is Sophoclean, since the audience of the *Oedipus* knew the myth, but *KOTOR* converts the audience of a myth into its mythographer.

10.3 *The Third Amnesty: Institutional*

Three institutional acts rewrote Revan after 2003. The first belongs to the sequel. *KOTOR II* (2004) asks the player to settle, in a dialogue in which another character questions its protagonist about the galaxy's recent past, whether Revan was a man or a woman and which path Revan took. This is an anamnesis by interview: the sequel consults the player's memory of their own playthrough as its archive, and the player's Revan survives as testimony.

The second came in 2011, when Karpyshyn's novel *Revan* and BioWare's massively multiplayer *Star Wars: The Old Republic* fixed the canonical Revan as a man who had returned to the light, married Bastila Shan, fathered a son, and departed into the Unknown Regions to confront a hidden Sith Emperor. The canon thereby performed upon millions of player-Revans what the Council performed upon one: it overwrote them with a single authorized identity. Players who had made Revan a woman, or who had ruled the Sith with Bastila beside them, found their Revans rendered apocryphal—an institutional noble lie about what "really" happened in a game whose premise was that what happened depended on the player.

The third came on 25 April 2014. Following Disney's acquisition of Lucasfilm in 2012, Lucasfilm announced that the Expanded Universe—the novels, comics and games beyond the films and the animated *Clone Wars*—would thenceforth be branded "Legends" and would no longer count as canon. The entire Old Republic era, and *KOTOR* with it, passed under institutional Lethe. The paradox is complete: a figure whose story is the story of administered forgetting was himself administratively forgotten by the franchise that made him.

10.4 *Canon and Archive*

Aleida Assmann's distinction between canon and archive clarifies what kind of forgetting the relabeling performed ("Canon and Archive," 2008). The canon is a culture's actively circulated memory, its working memory continually represented; the archive is passively stored memory, reference memory preserved but not in circulation and available for future recall. Active forgetting destroys; passive forgetting neglects; the archive preserves in neglect. The "Legends" relabeling did not destroy *KOTOR*. It moved the game from canon to archive, and archives are sites of potential anamnesis. The franchise has since recalled Legends material from its archive—Grand Admiral Thrawn, created for Timothy Zahn's *Heir to the Empire* (1991), returned in the animated series *Star Wars Rebels* in 2016. The archive is Lethe with a door. In this sense the third amnesty is a lethocratic act that stops short of erasure: a sealed record rather than a burned one.

10.5 *Archontic Power*

Derrida traced the word "archive" to the Greek *arkheion*, the house of the archons, the magistrates who guarded official documents and held the right to interpret them; archival power unites the consignation of records with hermeneutic privilege (*Archive Fever*, 1995). He linked the archive to Freud's death drive, since every archive selects, and every selection forgets: the desire to preserve is inseparable from the destruction it presupposes. The Jedi Council is an archontic body in this sense. Its archives on Dantooine hold records of the path Revan and Malak followed, and its masters decide what the protagonist may learn from them. The franchise's custodians of canon are archons of the same kind, deciding which memories circulate, so that the protagonist's struggle against the Council's archival control is mirrored, outside the fiction, by the players' relation to the franchise.

10.6 *Counter-Memory and the Poachers*

Against archontic power stands what Foucault called counter-memory, a genealogical practice that refuses the monumental continuity of official history and attends to dispersion, accident and the forgotten ("Nietzsche, Genealogy, History," 1971). Maurice Halbwachs showed that memory is always framed by social groups (*Les cadres sociaux de la mémoire*, 1925; *La mémoire collective*, 1950); Pierre Nora described *lieux de mémoire* as the sites where memory crystallizes once living milieux of memory have dissolved (*Les lieux de mémoire*, 1984–1992); Jan Assmann distinguished communicative memory, transmitted across roughly three generations, from cultural memory, fixed in institutions and texts (*Das kulturelle Gedächtnis*, 1992). The players' memory of Revan has the structure of communicative memory resisting cultural codification. Millions remember their own Revans—male and female, redeemed and enthroned—and transmit them in forums, fiction and modification.

Henry Jenkins, extending Michel de Certeau's account of reading as poaching (*The Practice of Everyday Life*, 1980), described fans as textual poachers who appropriate and rework official texts (*Textual Poachers*, 1992). The fan-produced restoration of material cut from the sequel—content recovered from the game's files and reassembled into a playable whole—is anamnesis in its most literal form: the recovery of what the producers' own archive had suppressed. The plurality of player-Revans is philosophically significant in its own right. Against the canon's single Revan stands Hesse's multitude (§8.5): Revan is not one but as many as there have been playthroughs, each a revenant of the same fictional predecessor and each answerable in its own way. The Reprise Criterion accommodates this plurality, because revenance is a relation rather than a substance. There can be many revenants of one Revan.

Borges anticipated this plurality in "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), whose imagined novel does not choose among alternatives but follows all of them at once, so that every outcome occurs in a branching web of times. The canon of 2011 chose one path through *KOTOR*; the players' memory preserves the garden.

10.7 *The Three Regimes in Reception*

The mnemonic regimes of the fiction recur in its reception. The franchise's custodianship of canon is lethocratic: it secures coherence by sealing the archive and overwriting variant memories. Fan grievance at "erasure"—campaigns to restore the Expanded Universe, enduring resentment of the relabeling—risks becoming mnemocratic, converting a remembered injury into an identity de-

fined by loss. Criticism and scholarship, this dissertation included, can occupy the anamnetic position: neither forgetting the archive nor nursing grievance over it, but holding the work in answerable custody, attending to what it disclosed, and returning it to circulation as an object of thought. The anamnetic republic of Chapter IX has its analogue in the republic of letters.

10.8 *Conclusion*

The Triple Amnesty completes the argument by showing that *KOTOR*'s subject—administered forgetting—was reenacted upon the work itself: by the Council within the fiction, by the player at its threshold, and by the franchise after its release. The work survives as its protagonist does, as a revenant: re-traversed by new players without memory of its original context, different in each reprise, and answerable, if criticism does its work, to the questions it first raised.

Conclusion

Toward an Anamnetic Republic

The Argument Restated

The Three Regimes

Contributions

Implications

Limitations

Directions for Future Research

Coda: Er Did Not Drink

The Argument Restated

Knights of the Old Republic is organized by a politics of memory. Its Platonic architecture frames the drama between a noble lie and the Myth of Er (Chapter III). Its Codes are technologies of forgetting and remembering (Chapter II). Its Council governs by exception, amnesty and choice architecture (Chapter IV). Its protagonist is a Revenant Subject whose identity follows the Reprise Criterion (Chapter V). Its procedural system constitutes a third mnemonic regime and casts the player as ludic legislator (Chapter VI). Its Sith enact a dialectic without synthesis (Chapter VII). Its heterodox voices and side-quests build an anamnetic third (Chapters VIII–IX). And its afterlife reenacts its subject in a Triple Amnesty (Chapter X). The light–dark binary the game advertises is real at the level of its fiction and false at the level of its structure: what the game actually contrasts are ways of administering the past.

The Three Regimes

	Lethocracy (Jedi)	Mnemocracy (Sith)	Anamnetic fidelity
Stance toward the past	Erase, seal, amnesty	Inflame, weaponize, avenge	Hold in answerable custody
Governing affect	*Apatheia*: affect suppressed	Passion: affect inflamed	Attention: affect understood and made active
Creed and form	Jedi Code: paratactic negations	Sith Code: *gradatio* toward broken chains	No code; practices of witness, forgiveness and promise
Philosophical lineage	Parmenides, the Stoa, Plato's noble lie, a monastic misprision of Buddhism	Heraclitus, Gnostic soteriology, Callicles, Nietzsche misread, Promethean grievance	Nietzsche's plastic power, Kierkegaard's repentance, Spinoza, Arendt, Ricoeur, Weil, Murdoch, Metz
Political form	Sovereign exception, choice architecture	Terror, conquest, institutionalized betrayal	Truth-telling, conditional reconciliation, renewed promise

	Lethocracy (Jedi)	Mnemocracy (Sith)	Anamnetic fidelity
Exemplars in the game	The Council's refabrication of Revan	Malak, the Korriban academy, the Star Forge	The side-quests, Jolee Bindo, the Rakatan Elders, Carth's forgiveness, Bastila's redemption
Historical analogue	Athenian amnesty of 403 BCE; Spain's pact of forgetting	French revanchism over Alsace-Lorraine after 1871; cycles of reprisal	South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission, imperfectly
Characteristic failure	The repressed returns	Self-consuming betrayal	Dependence on others' willingness to forgive

The historical column contains an instructive coincidence. The word *revanchism* entered political vocabulary through the French campaign to recover Alsace-Lorraine, annexed by the German Empire in 1871, and Renan delivered his 1882 lecture on national forgetting (§4.3) in the same republic during that campaign, arguing against German claims to the provinces based on language and descent. The Third Republic practiced both regimes at once: it asked citizens to forget the massacres of their own history while remembering a lost frontier. *KOTOR*'s Republic does the same, and neither regime, alone or combined, amounts to anamnetic fidelity.

Contributions

The dissertation makes six contributions. It offers a Platonic reading of the game that identifies the inverted noble lie and the Myth of Er as its structural frames and the Jedi as guardians severed from sovereignty. It offers a mnemopolitical reading of the Force binary, supported by formal analysis of the Codes: a Parmenidean litany of negation against a Heraclitean *gradatio*, with the Sith revealed as Nietzschean ressentiment rather than master morality. It introduces the Revenant Subject and the Reprise Criterion as a contribution to the philosophy of personal identity and responsibility, defining identity in the revenant sense by re-traversal, non-recollection, difference and answerability. It develops a procedural critique: the contradiction between scalar monism and diegetic dualism, the meter as moral ledger, the player as ludic legislator, and the save file as both amnesty and ring of Gyges. It reconstructs from the game's margins

an ethics of anamnetic fidelity and extends it into a political theory, anamnetic republicanism. And it proposes the Triple Amnesty as a model of how a work's themes are reenacted in its reception and institutional afterlife.

Implications

For the philosophy of personal identity, the Reprise Criterion separates numerical identity from answerability without dissolving responsibility, and so offers a framework for profound memory loss and radical conversion. One application concerns dementia and advance directives. Ronald Dworkin defended the precedent autonomy of an earlier self's directives over a later, demented self (*Life's Dominion*, 1993); Rebecca Dresser contested that view in defense of the present self's interests (1995). The criterion suggests a third position: the later self is the revenant of the earlier, and their relation is mediated by those who care for both, so that answerability is distributed across a community of address.

For transitional justice, anamnetic republicanism supplies a normative frame between amnesty and retribution. It explains why conditional amnesty for truth is superior to commanded forgetting, and why reprisal reproduces the injury it remembers. For game studies, the ludic legislator thesis shows how a procedural structure can reenact a work's political theology in the player's own conduct. Where Clint Hocking's influential notion of ludonarrative dissonance (2007) names a conflict between what a game's systems reward and what its story claims, *KOTOR* exhibits ludonarrative mirroring: the player's position in the system reproduces a position in the story. For the study of speculative fiction, the typology of revenant fictions (§5.10) locates the game in a family stretching from Sophocles to Dick and identifies interactive authorship of the false self as the medium's distinctive contribution to it.

Limitations

The study concentrates on the first game and treats its sequel chiefly as commentary; a full account of *KOTOR II* would require a dissertation of its own. Its philosophical sources are predominantly European, though Buddhist, Daoist, Confucian, Zoroastrian and Hindu texts have been engaged wherever the game's syncretism invites them. Authorial intention has been bracketed except where documented, and the onomastic readings are offered as hermeneutic affordances rather than claims about design. Dialogue has been paraphrased rather than transcribed. Finally, the study offers no empirical evidence about how players respond to the reveal or distribute their choices; its claims concern what the work affords, not what players do.

Directions for Future Research

Four lines of inquiry follow. The first is a reading of *KOTOR II* as Kreia's anti-Republic, a critique of the Platonic guardianship the first game stages. The second is the serial revenance of Revan across the long-running narrative of *Star Wars: The Old Republic*. The third is empirical: interviews and choice data could test whether the Reprise Criterion tracks players' own judgments of the protagonist's responsibility. The fourth is comparative: the amnesia narratives of the role-playing tradition, from *Planescape: Torment* onward, form a laboratory for the philosophy of personal identity that philosophers have scarcely entered.

Coda: Er Did Not Drink

The *Republic* ends with Er waking on his pyre, the one soul forbidden to drink from Lethe, sent back to tell what he saw so that his hearers might choose their lives with knowledge rather than by habit. The player who returns to *Knights of the Old Republic* after the first passage stands in Er's place. They have not drunk; they know who the protagonist is; they watch a new protagonist choose. What they owe that protagonist—and what any republic owes its forgotten founders, its peripheries and its victims—is neither the amnesty that seals nor the vengeance that inflames, but the custody that answers. The Old Republic is old because it remembers. It is a republic only if it can answer for what it remembers.

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